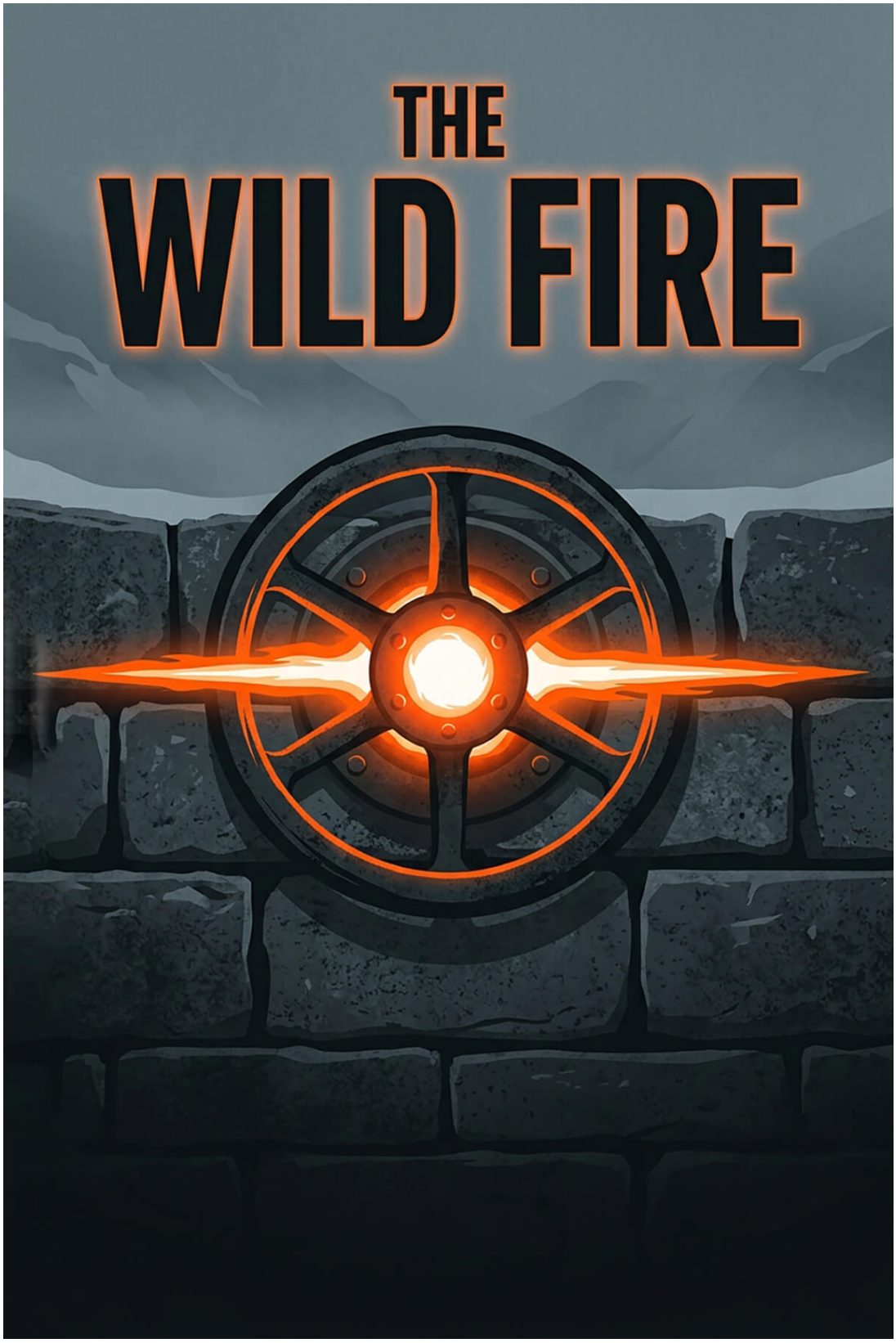

THE
WILD FIRE

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THE WILD FIRE

The city’s warmth is a scheduled lie.

For sixty years, the mountain city of Kelmouth has survived its winters because the Guild of Binders captures the wild fire spirits that pour down the pass each dry season. Second-year apprentice Priska Emberlyn has started to notice something no one else can feel: the fires she binds don’t move like wild things. They move like something that has been aimed.

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A Note from the Author / Publisher

Sometimes the most frightening villains aren't the ones who want to destroy the world — they're the ones who want to manage it perfectly.

The Wild Fire was born from a thought experiment about infrastructure and myth. We tend to think of magic in fantasy as something wild and untamed, but people have a habit of institutionalising everything they touch. I wanted to write a story about what happens when magic becomes municipal — when the people keeping a city safe are also keeping a sixty-year-old secret, and calling it civic duty.

Priska isn't a typical hero. She's not destined for greatness, and she doesn't give rousing speeches. She's an apprentice who notices a flaw in the world and refuses to look away from it. I hope you enjoy unravelling the archives alongside her.

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First Edition, 2026

A note on process: this book was produced with the assistance of AI language models — in the same way an author might use a ghostwriter or editor. The ideas, concept, characters, argument, and creative direction are entirely the author's own. AI was used as a writing tool — the thinking behind every page is human.

Acknowledgements

Thank you to the early readers whose feedback helped shape this book.

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Chapter 1: The Binding Mark

The smoke came before the fire, as it always did — thin threads rising from the upper brush line at a slant that had nothing to do with the wind. Priska watched them from the contain-point and kept her hands still.

Behind her, Ferath had stopped ten feet back. She could hear him breathing. She didn't look.

The sky above the pass was the particular grey that preceded sunrise by an hour, a colour that made everything at the same elevation look the same shade of ash and shadow. The scrub on the upper slope was leafless at this season, waist-high and thoroughly desiccated, stems so dry they barely registered as plant matter anymore. On still nights she'd heard it settle — a faint ticking from the root systems giving up moisture — and she'd learned to read that sound as the dry season's final accounting before the spirits began to move. By pre-dawn on a binding morning the scrub was practically crackling. She could smell it from two hundred yards: the specific char-before-burning that binders were trained to identify, somewhere between heated stone and something organic past the edge of its tolerance.

She pressed her palms together and felt the warmth building at the channel points — the thick ridge of tissue at the base of each thumb where binders concentrated their hold. Hers were still callusing. Six months left in her second year.

This was the difference between a training binding and the real season: in training there was always a senior binder within arm's reach, ready to step in. In the real season, the senior binder stood ten feet back and watched. If the binding failed it would fail, and Ferath would not be close enough to catch it. The distance was deliberate. It was the whole point.

She breathed out slowly and fixed her attention on the ridgeline. The smoke thickened.

The spirit came from the east.

She felt its approach through the rock before she saw the heat shimmer — a low resonance that ran up through the contain-point marker beneath her feet and into her soles. The marker was a scored line in the stone face where the hearth intake pipe surfaced from the Guild Hall below, capped and waiting. Her position was the cap. Her job was to stand between the spirit and the city at her back and make the redirect happen cleanly.

Wild spirits moved the way water moved through a broken landscape — probing, branching, doubling back when they found resistance. Every senior binder she'd ever observed had described the same initial contact: you read the approach by where the spirit wasn't going as much as by where it was. You felt for the ranging. You found the contain-point it would pass nearest and you got there first, and then you held still and let it come to you, because wild things did not walk into a trap directly.

She found the contain-point. She got there first.

The air in front of her buckled. Heat came down the slope in a concentrated wave that dried her

eyes immediately and pushed the breath back in her chest. She moved forward two steps — close enough — dropped her weight into her heels, and pressed both palms flat against the scored stone at the intake cap.

The channelling posture was not comfortable. Elbows locked, shoulders dropped and pulled back, feet spread to the width of the marker to either side. The point was not comfort. The point was to keep the alignment stable while the spirit transited through her hands and into the intake pipe below and from there down into the hearth three hundred feet under the mountain. She was not stopping it. She was redirecting it, giving it a path of least resistance that happened to end in a stone-walled chamber where the city could use what it left behind.

The heat built. Her palms flared — not burning, that wasn't what Marks were, but the particular deep thermal pressure of channelling, like holding a river's force between cupped hands and refusing to let it push you sideways. Her vision went narrow at the edges. She kept her weight centred and held.

And in the moment before full contact — in the two or three seconds when the spirit's leading edge was still approaching and she was still reading it rather than holding it — she felt something she had no name for.

The approach was wrong.

Not wrong in the way nerves made things wrong, not the distortion of too much adrenaline finding pattern in noise. Wrong in a specific physical way: the spirit moved with a directness she hadn't been trained to expect. No ranging to either side of the contain-point. No probe-and-withdrawal when it registered her presence. It came straight at her, at the intake pipe, at the hearth below — with the quality of something that already knew the path it was taking. Linear. Compressed. Without the doubling-back that was supposed to be the basic signature of a wild spirit's approach.

She held. The spirit transited. Three full minutes of pressure, the heat cresting and then dropping as the leading edge exhausted into the intake, and then it was over. She was standing with her arms still locked, her ears ringing, her palms pressed against stone that was merely warm.

She stepped back. Dropped her arms. Breathed.

Ferath came up beside her. He examined the intake cap, glanced at the slope above, looked at her. He said, "Clean." That was all. In the dry season's formal usage, it meant she'd passed.

The Containment Mark came up on her left wrist over the next quarter-hour as they walked back down the pass. She'd seen the marks on senior binders all her life — the grey-black branching that spread from the wrist in the pattern of a scorch or a frost, a record of every major binding absorbed. Ferath's covered most of his left arm, the older branching faded to silver at the edges. Her own was new and small and still generating its own low heat, the branching settling into her skin as it finished its work.

She looked at it for a moment, then pulled her cuff down.

The pass road switchbacked down the mountain's east face, and from the upper turns she could see most of Kelmouth below — the city wedged into the rock corridor, stone-built and compact, every roofline flush to the cliff face on one side or another to keep the dry-season winds from finding purchase. The hearth vents were already exhaling their heat-shimmer above the buildings, thin and colourless in the morning light. Forty thousand people warming themselves on bound fire. She'd grown up in the lower district looking up at those vents every morning and not thinking about them particularly, the way you didn't think about water that came when you opened a valve.

Now she'd been the person who put something in the pipes, and the city looked different in a way she didn't quite have words for yet.

Ferath said nothing else on the walk down. He wasn't a talker; she'd known that since her first week of second-year. He communicated in adjustments — a small correction to her stance during a training bind, a single-word debrief after a session — and she'd learned to read those adjustments more closely than other instructors' full explanations. He had said *clean*. That was the whole review.

The wrongness from the binding kept circling at the edge of her attention. She tested it against the training manual's language — *erratic, probing, ranging, reactive to resistance* — and found the gap, and could not close it.

By the time they reached the Guild Hall gate she had decided she'd misread something. First real solo binding, the highest-stakes day of her second year, of course her perception had skewed. She filed it and went inside.

* * *

The seasonal intake ceremony was held in the hearth chamber on the north face of the Guild Hall, a room that had been built around the containment hearths rather than the other way around. The three hearths were anchored into the mountain rock itself — each the height of two men, stone-faced and iron-shuttered — and the accumulated thermal energy of the season's bindings was stored inside them in a form that would heat the city through winter. Distribution pipes ran out from each hearth into the wall and from there into Kelmouth's grid: to the buildings, the kilns, the aqueducts that kept the mountain-pass water moving through the cold months. Without the hearths the city contracted in winter. Without the binders the hearths went empty.

Everyone in Kelmouth knew this. The seasonal intake ceremony existed, in part, to make sure they continued to know it.

Priska stood with the other second-years along the north wall while Guildmaster Corvain Ashe addressed the assembled apprentices from the raised platform at the chamber's centre. He was a large man in his middle years, grey at the temples, with eight Containment Marks visible — she'd heard the count from older apprentices, who kept track — running from his wrists to his

shoulders on both arms, with one branch crossing the left side of his jaw in a thin line that reached toward his ear. He wore his ceremonial jacket open at the collar in the way senior binders did at formal occasions, so the marks were legible.

He spoke the way someone spoke when they'd said the same things so many times they'd stopped hearing them as words and started hearing them as the shape of something necessary. The founding of the Guild. The Great Wild Blaze sixty years past, the hundred dead and the city nearly lost before the first binders learned to hold a spirit long enough to redirect it into containment. The development of the hearth network over the decades since. The work that kept the city alive through every winter the dry season left behind it.

Around her, the third-years had the particular blankness of people hearing something they'd already absorbed. A first-year beside her was listing slightly sideways, trying to see Ashe's jaw mark. Priska watched Ashe instead, which was how she noticed the thing she noticed.

He believed it. That was the specific quality she was reading — not performance, not the elevated register of someone reciting a duty, but the conviction of a man who had arranged his entire understanding of the world around a set of premises and found, every year, that the world confirmed them. The hearths were necessary. The binders were necessary. The danger was real and the Guild's response to it was right and sufficient. He had lived in a frame that produced those conclusions, and he spoke from inside it with the ease of someone who had never found a reason to step outside.

That, she thought, was its own kind of interesting.

After the address the chamber opened to informal assembly. Senior binders moved through the room with the ease of people comfortable in institutions; the apprentices moved around them with the fractionally less comfortable ease of people learning to be. Priska collected a cup of the hot water that was always provided at these occasions and positioned herself near the north wall, where she had a clear view of the whole chamber.

Senior binders received congratulations for the season's work. There was a particular handshake that senior binders used among themselves — right hand to right hand, but with the thumb pressing briefly against the inside of the other person's wrist, over the Marks. She'd noticed it at her first ceremony and worked out what it meant: a check. Everyone still here. Everyone still intact. She'd be part of that exchange in a few years, if she held the second-year pace and got through to advanced certifications. She'd be part of a lot of things she was only watching now.

She watched Ashe circulate through the room. He spoke to each senior binder in turn, leaning in slightly, touching an arm here and there — a physical grammar of familiarity that had probably been built over decades. He listened. He remembered names she'd only just learned, and details she hadn't known were his to know. He had the Mark count of someone who had done binding work well into his middle years before moving into administration, and he wore it as exactly that: experience, not decoration.

The hearths were directly visible from where she stood — the iron shutters, the distribution pipes going out into the walls below, the intake pipes surfacing from the slope above. She'd

studied the basic schematics in second-year theory and had seen the chamber plenty of times, but she'd never stood in it after a binding with time to look at it properly. The system was larger than it seemed on paper. The pipes went in many more directions than the simplified diagram suggested, branching through the walls toward different quarters of the city, each branch with its own valve assembly.

Along the east wall, flanking the hearths, she noticed a set of smaller mechanisms she hadn't paid specific attention to before. Iron-bodied, flush-mounted into the stone, each with a wheel handle worn dark at the grip from years of handling. There were four of them, evenly spaced, positioned between the main hearth shutters. She crossed the room to read the nearest label, a line of small stamped letters set into the metal above the wheel.

Thermal safety regulator.

She didn't ask about them. There were always components she hadn't had explained yet, and the approach she'd found most useful was to note them and wait for the context to arrive. She finished her water and returned to the apprentice group as the senior binders began moving toward the door.

* * *

Her dormitory room had one window facing the pass, a bed frame, a shelf, a writing board, and a lamp that burned lower than it should have because the oil she was allocated ran slightly thin — a supply issue she'd raised twice and stopped raising. She had adapted.

She sat on the edge of the bed with her cuff rolled back and looked at the new Mark on her left wrist. Still warm, still settling, the branching distinct in the lamplight: grey-black, running from the base of her thumb up toward the inside of her wrist. By morning it would be fully set. Permanent. She had earned it doing real work — she knew that. She had held a real spirit through a real binding and redirected it into a real hearth. The Mark was exactly what it was supposed to be.

The wrongness from the binding kept returning.

She tested it again, deliberately: the manual's language against the memory of what she'd felt. *Erratic.* No. *Probing.* No. *Ranging, reactive to resistance.* Not what she'd felt. What she'd felt had a direction — a single, unwavering direction — and the quality of something that had been going that way for longer than the seconds she'd observed it.

The obvious explanation was nerves. She'd been trained for exactly that error: the instinct to over-read an unfamiliar situation, to impose meaning on an experience that was simply new. She was nineteen years old and had just done the hardest thing her second year required. Of course her perception had been off.

She lay down and looked at the ceiling. The Mark on her wrist radiated a low, steady warmth against the wool of her sleeve. Outside the window the pass was dark and quiet, the city's hearth

vents sending up thin columns of heat-shimmer she could see against the lighter darkness of the sky.

She turned over and tried to sleep.

Chapter 2: What the Widow Remembers

The courtesy call list came with a note from Ferath that said the visits were customary for second-years and otherwise left it at that. Four names. Widow Kessel was the third.

The lower pass district sat far enough below the Guild Hall that the altitude shift was noticeable — fewer steps at this elevation, the air slightly less thin, the streets shared-wall and crowded where the upper passes were rock-cut and spare. Priska walked down through the market quarter and found the turning at the fourth street. The houses here were built into the contour in rows that stepped down the slope, back walls anchored into the mountain, sharing heat through the stonework in a way that made the whole street warmer than the open road above. The city made use of everything the pass geography offered. Space, warmth, shelter from the wind: nothing went unused.

The house with the better-maintained door was the one she was looking for. She knocked.

The widow Kessel opened it before Priska had fully dropped her hand, looked her over in one efficient assessment, and stepped back to let her in.

"You're the second-year," she said. "Come in, then."

The interior was warmer than the temperature outside justified, which meant Kessel was running her hearth connection high and had been for some time. The furniture was solid and old — bought once, repaired when needed, not replaced. Kessel herself was in her seventies, sharp-faced and direct in her movements, with the complete unselfconsciousness of someone who had arranged her home exactly as she wanted it and had not reconsidered in years. She put a kettle on the iron stand above the hearth vent without asking whether Priska wanted anything.

Priska sat in the chair indicated and kept her cuffs down.

"Binder Ferath sent the letter," Kessel said, not turning from the hearth. "I know what the call is for. Second-years visit the old binders' families. It's a good tradition. Oren would have been on someone's list, if he'd survived me." She said this with no particular weight — the arithmetic of it, nothing more. "How long have you been in training? You're young for a second-year."

"Nineteen. Standard civic entry."

"Oren was twenty-three when he started. Older intake in those days — the training wasn't systematised the way it is now. He learned most of it by direct observation. Watching senior binders work and then replicating it, with someone standing close enough to intervene if something went badly." She brought two cups to the table and set one in front of Priska. The tea was very dark and smelled astringent. "Slower to produce a competent binder, but the ones it produced tended to be careful. He was careful." She sat down across the table and looked at Priska's hands. "That's a new mark. This season?"

Priska pulled back her left cuff. The branching had fully set now, the heat gone, the grey-black of it permanent. "Five days ago."

Kessel studied it for a moment — the particular look of someone who had spent years watching marks appear and settle on someone they knew. “Clean lines. Ferath trained you well.” She said it as a fact. Then: “Oren had three marks by the end of his career. The last one he earned at fifty-two, from a late-season binding, and he said afterward it was the hardest physical work he’d done in twenty years. That season the spirits were larger than the maps predicted.” She wrapped both hands around her cup. “He liked it. The work itself. He wasn’t someone who liked many things especially, but the binding he liked — the way some people like difficult problems, not because they’re pleasant but because they require your complete attention and don’t leave room for anything else.”

The tea was too hot and slightly bitter. Priska drank it anyway.

* * *

The question about the hearth infrastructure — whether Oren had worked during the early years of the grid’s expansion — turned out to be the right one to start with. Kessel had clear views on what the network had meant for Kelmouth and did not require prompting to share them.

Oren had begun his binding career forty years ago, during the period when the distribution grid covered perhaps half the city. The lower pass district had come online in his seventh year of active work. Before that, Kessel said, the winters here had a particular quality that younger residents did not understand anymore — not catastrophic, nothing that drove people away permanently, but a grinding, close-quarters difficulty that changed the shape of every cold month. Oil lamps and wood fires in a stone city at altitude. Windows sealed from the first frost to the first thaw. Three layers of clothing indoors by mid-winter. The mountain-pass aqueducts froze over every year for six to eight weeks and had to be cleared by hand. The kilns couldn’t run at the temperatures the craftsmen needed and so certain goods — glass, refined metal, treated leather — became scarce and expensive every winter from the first cold snap onward.

“You managed,” Kessel said. “It was survivable. People survived worse, in other cities in other seasons, and people in this city survived it every year. But there is a specific texture to life in a cold place when you’re spending most of your energy maintaining a temperature that keeps you functional, and very little energy on anything else. You get through winter. You don’t do much else in it.”

She looked out the window at the street. The hearth vents of the houses opposite were exhaling their thin heat-shimmer into the cold air.

“The grid changed that,” she said. “Completely and permanently, for everyone it reached. We started having winters instead of surviving them. I don’t think that’s a small thing, and I don’t think enough people who grew up after the grid was complete understand what the binders actually gave this city. The Guild takes credit for a great deal.” She returned her attention to her cup. “Most of it they deserve.”

She talked about Oren's career: specific bindings she remembered him describing, seasons that had been difficult or straightforward, the particular pride he'd had in the third-year apprentice cohort he'd supervised for a decade near the end of his working life. Priska listened and asked small questions when the conversation paused, and the hour worked itself forward into the later afternoon.

* * *

The Great Wild Blaze came up on its own, the way large events did with someone who had lived long enough that history and memory occupied the same space. Kessel had been twelve when it happened. Her family had been in the lower pass district then as now, and she described the morning it began with the specificity of someone who had kept the memory intact rather than studied it afterward.

"Oren was years from binding training when the Blaze came," she said, "but he talked about watching the binders work that morning as one of the things that made him think seriously about the Guild as a profession. Something about seeing people who knew what to do when no one else did." She refilled Priska's cup without asking. "My family's house was on the upper side of this street. We could see the whole pass from the roof."

She described the morning: the smell arriving before anything visible, the sharpness of it — heated stone and something organic and wrong — coming down on the wind hours before the smoke. Then the smoke coming up from the east first, from the high pass above the city, a pale column thickening through the pre-dawn dark while most of Kelmouth was still asleep. Her mother had come up to the roof at first light and stood beside her watching it. By mid-morning she'd decided to move them to her aunt's house in the lower quarter, below the slope, away from the approach. They'd taken what they could carry, which was not much, and walked down.

The sky above the east ridge had gone orange by noon. The columns of smoke were no longer pale.

She talked about the evacuation: the routes that had worked and the one that hadn't, the streets too narrow for the volume of people, a cart overturned in the market lane that someone had to move by hand. The binders' containment line in the western approach, which had held and then briefly broken and then held again. The days afterward, when the city had counted its losses and found them smaller than they'd feared, and what her parents had said when they walked back up the hill to find the house intact.

Priska said: "You mentioned the smoke came from the east first."

Kessel paused. "Yes."

"The Guild's historical records say the first ignition point was in the western brush."

Kessel set her cup down and considered this with the mild attention she gave most things Priska had said — measured, not dismissive, but not particularly engaged. "Then I was looking the

wrong direction," she said. "I was twelve years old and watching from a rooftop. The Guild had trained observers on the containment approaches. They'd know better than I would where the first ignition was."

"But you're certain about the direction. East."

"I'm certain about what I saw." She said this without defensiveness. "That's not the same as being certain about what caused it. Maybe there were two ignition points and I was only seeing one of them. Maybe something in the east caught from secondary spread before the binders' line formed. I don't know how fires work that precisely." She picked up her cup again. "It's the kind of detail that sounds like it matters if you don't know the full picture, and stops sounding like it matters once you do. The Guild spent years documenting everything about that season. I spent one morning on a roof."

Priska kept her voice even. "Have you mentioned it before? The east-pass direction?"

"A few times, over the years." She was looking at the far wall with an expression Priska couldn't quite place — not regret, not dismissal, something that had been arrived at through a long process of reconsideration. "The first time I mentioned it was to Oren, when we were first together. He looked into it — asked some questions of people he knew in the Guild — and came back and told me the official account was thorough and the witnesses were credible, and that memory in high-stress situations was unreliable in exactly the ways mine seemed to be. He wasn't unkind about it. He was being careful, the way he was always careful." She drank the last of her tea. "After that I tried it a few more times over the years, with other people, and the response was always some version of the same thing. I was young, I was frightened, the binders had documentation and I had a rooftop. Eventually I stopped bringing it up. It only confused things, and it didn't change what had happened either way."

She said this as a simple statement of what she'd concluded. Not resignation exactly, but a decision that had been made a long time ago and had not been revisited because there'd been no particular reason to.

The kitchen was quiet for a moment. The hearth vent's warmth was so constant it had stopped being noticeable.

Priska said: "How certain are you about the east pass specifically? Not just eastward — that particular pass."

Kessel looked at her with slightly sharper attention than she'd been applying. "Why are you asking?"

"I'm trying to understand what you saw."

Kessel considered her for a moment, the way she'd been considering everything since Priska arrived — directly, with no particular interest in performing uncertainty she didn't feel. "I grew up looking at that pass every morning of my childhood. I know what smoke above it looks like from this street. I could describe the shape of the ridge to you now." She seemed to hear something in her own certainty that surprised her slightly, as though she'd expected, after

decades of self-correction, to find the memory less clear than it still was. “It was the east pass,” she said. Then she moved on. “Now. You said Ferath is your instructor. Is he still using the Kestal method for second-year distance reads, or has he finally updated the curriculum?”

* * *

Priska walked back up to the Guild Hall through the market quarter in the late afternoon, the two things sitting alongside each other in her mind the way two objects sat on a table when you weren’t yet sure whether they were related or simply adjacent.

The first: the binding, five days ago. The approach that hadn’t ranged, hadn’t probed, hadn’t done the doubling-back that was supposed to be the basic signature of a wild spirit moving freely. The quality of it — linear, compressed, something that knew where it was going. She had labelled it first-solo-binding nerves and filed it. She had been very confident that was the right label.

The second: the east pass. Smoke from the east pass, on the morning the Great Wild Blaze had started sixty years ago. The Guild’s official record said the western brush. Kessel had watched from a rooftop and seen the eastern smoke clearly and spent six decades assuming she’d been mistaken, because why wouldn’t she assume that — the binders had documentation, trained observers, a complete account, and she had a twelve-year-old’s memory of a frightening morning. The Guild’s account was more complete than hers. She had said so herself. She had convinced herself of it across sixty years and one conversation with her husband who had checked with the Guild and come back with confirmation that the official record was thorough and her memory unreliable.

Priska crossed the market quarter without seeing much of it. The vendors were loud. The supply carts for the end-of-dry-season restocking had the narrow lanes half-blocked. She moved through the press and came out the far side into the quieter approach to the upper Guild road.

Neither thing was evidence of anything, taken alone. A first-year binding that felt wrong was much more likely to reflect a first-year binder’s limitations than anything irregular about the fire. And one woman’s sixty-year-old rooftop memory, already self-corrected on the advice of her binder husband who had looked into it, was not a credible counter to a Guild record with named witnesses and a full investigation behind it.

Together, though. Together they pointed somewhere. And Priska had a specific, established problem with patterns that pointed somewhere — she could not let them alone until she’d checked whether they resolved.

She told herself: she was not looking for a conspiracy. She was checking a gap. It was the same thing she did with the training manual when she found a passage that didn’t match what she’d observed in practice. She checked until the discrepancy closed or until she understood why it existed, and then she moved on.

The Guild Hall’s historical archive held the official binding records from the Great Wild Blaze.

Public access. Any second-year apprentice could pull them for research purposes. She could look at the ignition-point documentation, the witness accounts, whatever the Guild had formally recorded about where the Blaze started. If the record was complete and the witnesses credible, the gap would close and she'd have nothing to think about. If the record had something she didn't understand yet, she'd need to understand it.

Either way, she'd know.

She went up the Guild Hall steps and inside.

Chapter 3: The Wrong Direction

The historical archive opened at first bell, and she was there when it did.

The binder who managed the collection had taken a knee injury in his third active season and spent the subsequent twelve years in records management, which he approached with the specific thoroughness of someone who had, after some internal accounting, decided this was work worth doing well. He looked up when Priska came in, assessed her, and returned to his cataloguing. She was neither a disruption nor a complication. Fine.

Three rooms, stone shelving, pressed-board cases labelled by year and category along each wall. The mountain rock at the archive's back kept the temperature constant and the humidity low, which was the whole point — vellum and pressed board were survivable formats, but not in damp. The smell was the smell of old dry things: dust and lanolin from the treated cases, and underneath both of those something older that she'd never been able to name precisely. The accumulation of sixty years of institutional record-keeping in a confined space. All the decisions and events that had been written down and stored here because someone had decided they needed to exist permanently.

She went straight to the historical section and found the binding reports from the Great Wild Blaze year in twenty minutes. Three pressed-board cases of different sizes — the variation reflecting the volume of documentation generated at each phase of the crisis. The smallest case held the pre-fire survey reports: terrain assessments, dry-season condition ratings, the supply inventories that told the Guild what resources it had available before the fires came. The largest held the containment records: binders' logs from the eight days the Blaze burned, one entry per shift per binder, written in the moment. The third case held the aftermath documentation.

She opened the containment case.

What she was looking for was filed at the front. A single-page report, formal in its register, on the Guild's standard headed vellum: *Determination of Initial Ignition Point*. Produced by a panel of four senior binders who had conducted a physical survey of the origin terrain on the third day of the Blaze, when the fire line had been stabilised enough for ground examination. Their conclusion was stated plainly: the initial ignition had occurred in the western brush approach, at a specified grid reference in the lower slope west of the city. The report described the physical indicators — char pattern, heat distribution, the direction of the first spread — that had led the panel to this determination. The language was precise and professional. The document showed every mark of a carefully produced formal record.

Four witnesses. She wrote down their names on the scrap of pressed board she'd brought: Beren Calt, Ossin Marke, Devin Ashel, Pren Wollam.

* * *

The binder rolls were a master ledger of everyone who had completed training and formally

registered with the Guild, from its founding to the present year, in eight bound volumes cross-referenced by decade. Finding a binder in the rolls was straightforward: you pulled the relevant decade volume, checked the alphabetical index, and found the entry within a few minutes. The entries were detailed — full name, training cohort, primary assignment district, any subsequent roles, retirement or death notation.

She pulled the volumes covering the three decades around the Blaze year and looked for each of the four names.

Beren Calt: no entry in any of the eight volumes.

Ossin Marke: no entry.

Devin Ashel: one entry, but a different person — a woman who had completed training thirty-eight years after the Blaze, still in active service, her career fully documented across four separate ledgers. Her birth year made her approximately ten years old at the time of the Blaze. Not the Devin Ashel she was looking for.

Pren Wollam: no entry.

She returned the rolls and pulled the intake records. A different ledger system entirely — organised by training cohort rather than individual registration, listing everyone who had entered the apprentice program in a given year. She worked backward from the Blaze year by a decade and forward by a decade. None of the four names appeared in any cohort.

She checked the seasonal assignment records for the Blaze year itself — the roster of every binder working that season. Long lists, carefully maintained: name, assigned approach, certification level, team designation. She went through every page. Two of the four witnesses weren't there. The other two she couldn't locate with confidence after forty minutes of searching; there were some damage-related gaps in those particular ledgers where the ink had run.

She sat back and thought about it.

The way the records worked, in the normal run of things, was that a binder appeared in multiple places across their career. The intake ledger caught them when they entered training. The binder rolls caught them when they registered. The seasonal assignments caught them each year they worked. If they moved into administrative or teaching roles, those records caught them too. And at the end — retirement, death in service, relocation out of the region — there was a final notation. Cross-references were the whole point. The system was designed so that any binder's history was reconstructable from multiple independent sources.

Four witnesses on the most significant document in Guild history left no cross-references she could find. They appeared, signed, and vanished.

The most likely explanation was archive gaps. Sixty years of record-keeping produced them, especially in the early decades when the Guild's administrative systems were still being standardised. A binder registered and active in the founding period might appear in some

records and not others, depending on which systems had actually been in operation at the time. The Blaze had been a crisis — documentation had probably suffered in exactly the ways that would leave these kinds of gaps.

The archive attendant could tell her where the early ledger gaps were, if she asked.

She didn't ask. She wrote down the anomaly and moved on.

The index catalogue was on the east shelf of the third room — a single large ledger that indexed not just the archive's own holdings but the broader institutional record: where to find documents held by other bodies, what other collections existed, what was restricted and why. She'd used it once in first year for a research reference. She opened it now to the Blaze-year entries and worked through them.

Near the bottom of the relevant page, a single line:

City Prefect's Records, Year of the Blaze and Prior Three Years: civic administration, prefect's fire reports, survey correspondence. Held: City Records Hall, Administrative District. Access: Guildmaster's letter required for Guild personnel under institutional authority; city administrative standing otherwise.

She read it twice.

The city's own records — the civic prefect's fire reports from the Blaze year, produced by the city's government before the Guild had existed long enough to have its own administrative systems — required a Guildmaster's authorisation letter for any Guild member who wanted to access them through Guild channels. The records weren't in the Guild archive. They had never been in the Guild archive. They were held by the city's own administrative body, in the city's own building, as part of the city's civic record. But accessing them under Guild institutional authority required the Guildmaster's personal sign-off.

She thought about the logic of that for a moment. The Guild was not the city. The Guildmaster was not a city official. In what arrangement did the Guildmaster of a professional organisation have authority over who from that organisation accessed a civic government's historical records?

She couldn't answer that from here. She noted the address — City Records Hall, Administrative District — and both access routes. The Guild route required the Guildmaster's letter. The civic route required city administrative standing, which meant she'd need to go in as a private citizen or attached to someone who had that standing.

She thought about who she knew with city administrative standing who also had a legitimate reason to be looking at sixty-year-old fire reports.

One person. She closed the index and returned it to the shelf.

On her way out she passed the current-records section. The seasonal ignition maps were there — public access, available to all apprentices for approach planning. She pulled the last fifteen years' worth, signed them out under the standard research provision, rolled them under her

arm, and left.

* * *

She was returning the last Blaze records case to its shelf when she realised Tobin Ashe was in the aisle.

He hadn't made any noise coming in. He was standing ten feet from her, near the end of the shelving row, and he was looking at the cases she'd already returned with the specific, focused attention of someone who had noted which ones had been displaced.

"The Blaze reports," he said. Not a question.

"Historical research." She kept her voice even. "Second-year assignment."

"Of course." He came down the aisle toward her, unhurried, stopping a few feet away. He was twenty years old and had the ease of someone who had grown up inside the Guild Hall rather than arrived in it — who had walked these corridors since childhood, eaten at these tables, and had never experienced the building as institutional so much as domestic. He was taller than her and wore that casually, the way he wore most things. "I've read those particular records myself. They're thorough. Comprehensive, really, given the conditions the documentation was produced under."

She said nothing. Waiting to see what this was.

"Assignment board is posted," he said. "Final seasonal binding in twelve days. You're listed as secondary on the east-approach team." His gaze moved briefly to her left wrist — the Mark was under her cuff, but he'd have seen it at the intake ceremony. "First real season. You'd be better served spending your research time on the containment sequences for your assigned approach than on sixty-year-old ignition reports."

He turned slightly as if that were the end of it, then paused.

"The hearth needs filling," he said, "before it matters where the fire comes from."

Then he walked out of the aisle. She heard his footsteps cross the outer room. She heard the archive door open and close. The attendant's pen resumed its steady scratching from the front desk.

She stood where she was and thought about what had just happened. Tobin Ashe had been in the historical archive at first bell, and he had been looking at the cases she'd returned. He had known which records she'd pulled. Whether he had followed her in or been there before her she couldn't determine — he'd been at the end of the row, not the entrance. He had been waiting, or watching, or both.

He had been uncomfortable. Not threatened, not aggressive, but the specific discomfort of someone who knew the territory of a conversation they hadn't wanted to be having, and had handled it competently anyway.

Which meant there was territory to know about. Which meant there was something to look for.

She finished returning the last case. She walked out.

* * *

Her dormitory room was large enough for a bed, a shelf, a writing board, and a floor, and the floor was what she needed. She moved the chair to the corner, unrolled the first seasonal map, weighted its corners with her two heaviest books and a water cup, and spread the second map beside it.

The maps documented each dry season's fire events: the city's containment structures in grey, the binders' standard approach lines in blue, and the documented ignition origin points in red notation. Each significant fire — the ones requiring full binding teams, officially classified as major wild-fire events — had its origin marked with a dated notation and a confidence rating. The confidence rating indicated how precisely the team had been able to determine the origin before containment work obscured the physical evidence. Most significant fires rated high confidence. The binders had been thorough.

She started with the most recent year and worked backward.

The current season's maps she knew in outline from her approach assignments — she'd studied them for the containment positioning exercise at the start of second year. Three significant fires this season so far, all from the east slope, origins marked at grid references she'd memorised. She set that map aside and looked at the year before.

Two significant fires that year. East slope, high approach. Both origins she noted.

She spread three maps, then four. Arranged them in chronological order on the floor and crouched down to look at them together.

By the eighth map she had stopped moving between them and was simply looking.

She knew the theory of wild fire distribution well enough to have passed the second-year probability exam. Wild-fire spirits emerged from mountain terrain in response to a combination of factors: dry-season air pressure, heat accumulation in the rock, wind patterns that could concentrate or disperse the spirits before they reached containment range. Terrain features could bias the distribution — a funnel formation, a slope aspect that collected heat — and experienced binders used that bias to plan their approach lines. But no individual terrain point produced repeated ignitions at the same location year after year. The mountain was large and complex and the spirits responded to the whole of it. The course material was explicit on this: you planned around broad probability zones, not around specific repeat points, because repeat points were statistically impossible over any meaningful run of seasons.

The fifteen maps in front of her said otherwise.

The significant fire origins — the ones that had required full binding teams and earned formal classification as major events — were clustered around three points on the east slope. Not in identical grid squares every year; there was two or three squares of variation from year to year, which gave it the look of natural scatter. But she took her scrap of pressed board and marked each origin point with a small notation, then laid the marked board over the first map, then the second, and the circles stacked. Not randomly. Three zones. The same three zones, rotating through them with the consistency of something that knew where it was supposed to be.

She sat down on the floor among the maps and stayed there for a while.

The variation was the interesting part. If the origins had been perfectly identical every year, it would have looked wrong immediately — someone would have noticed, would have written it into the seasonal planning notes, would have flagged it as anomalous terrain. The two-or-three-square variation was exactly enough to make each individual year look like normal terrain bias. It was only looking at all fifteen years at once, stacking them, that the underlying pattern became undeniable.

Wild fires did not produce this. Wild fires did not produce any pattern this tight, this consistent, this specifically organised around three return points across fifteen consecutive seasons. She had been trained to know what wild fire distribution looked like and she knew, looking at the floor, that this was not it.

She wasn't sure what it was instead. She had a strong, specific instinct about that, and the instinct was the kind that made her want to go back and recheck every assumption she'd made in the last ten days to find where her reasoning had gone wrong.

The east slope. The same three points. Fifteen years.

The map looked like a schedule.

She hadn't said that aloud yet.

Chapter 4: Kessel's Archive

She went back to the lower pass district two days after her archive work, with a specific question.

Kessel opened the door before Priska had finished knocking — which Priska was beginning to think was simply how Kessel operated, a permanent alertness to whoever might be at her door — and looked at her for a moment.

"You have something to ask," Kessel said. "Come in."

The tea was already on. The same chair was available. Priska sat down and did not take off her coat, which Kessel noted without commenting.

"In the Guild Hall archive," Priska said, "there's a reference to city records from the Blaze year. The city prefect's fire reports, held at the city records hall in the Administrative District. Guild members can access them with a Guildmaster's letter. Citizens with civic standing can access them directly."

Kessel was looking at her with the attentiveness she gave to things that were worth understanding. "Oren's widow status counts as civic standing for historical Guild records," she said. "I've used it twice — once for a property question, once for a pension matter." She wrapped her hands around her cup. "What are you looking for?"

"I'll know when I find it."

Kessel considered this for a moment. Not performing consideration — actually thinking. Then she said: "Yes. Not tomorrow. The day after, tenth bell."

"That's fine."

Kessel drank her tea. Outside, the lower pass district went about its late-morning business — cart wheels on stone, the distant noise of the market quarter two streets over. "You're a careful person," she said.

"Yes."

"Most second-years aren't." She said this without particular judgment. It was simply what she'd observed.

* * *

The city records hall was in the Administrative District, three streets from the Guild Hall but a different world from it: civic rather than professional, functional rather than commemorative. The building had been put up thirty years before the Guild existed and showed it — broader corridors, lower ceilings, stonework that was adequate rather than impressive. The records themselves were held in the lower level, in rooms with wooden shelving and tin-labelled drawers

that smelled of old ink and the particular staleness of carefully maintained things that were rarely consulted.

The attendant at the desk was a middle-aged civil servant who examined Kessel's widow documentation without expression, made a notation in his access register, and led them to the prefect's records section. He showed them which drawers held the Blaze-year reports and left them to it.

The prefect's records were different in texture from the Guild archive. Broader vellum sheets, a more cramped and hurried hand — the writing of someone capturing events rather than producing formal documents. The fire reports from the Blaze year were stored together with agricultural survey reports and water-allocation notices from the same period, bundled because they shared a year rather than because they related to each other. Priska worked through them in order, Kessel standing a little to one side, watching the work without quite following it.

She found the first-sighting report in the third bundle.

A single page, civic in its heading: the city prefect's notation of the first smoke reports received by the civic watch on the morning the Blaze began. The watch had received reports from the upper residential district at first bell — smoke visible from the east approach, coming from the high pass. The prefect had dispatched an assessment team at second bell. By third bell, with the team reporting significant fire in the east approach and spreading south, the prefect had formally requested Guild binding response.

First confirmed smoke: high east pass.

Consistent with what Kessel had seen from her family's roof. Inconsistent with the Guild's formal determination of initial ignition — the western brush, a grid reference, signed by four witnesses who appeared in no other Guild record.

Kessel had come to stand at her shoulder. Priska held out the document without saying anything. Kessel read it. What shifted in her face was not surprise exactly — it was the specific adjustment of someone who has spent sixty years persuading herself that her memory was wrong and is now looking at paper that says it wasn't.

"Well," Kessel said.

Priska was already moving to the building register section. The index had noted the prefect's records covered the Blaze year and the three prior years. She wanted the prior years. She pulled the building registers for the two years before the Blaze and began working through them systematically.

The building register was what it sounded like: a listing of all significant construction and installation work registered with the city in each year, organised by district, each entry brief — a description, a responsible contractor or body, an authorisation stamp. The handwriting here was even more compressed than the fire reports, a clerk's hand trained to produce maximum information in minimum space. Most entries were routine. A new bakehouse in the market quarter. Repairs to a bridge span in the lower pass. A well lining replaced in the residential

district. A storage building commissioned by a merchant in the south-approach quarter. The city maintaining itself, one entry at a time, across years that had otherwise been unremarkable.

She read through the infrastructure sections carefully, approach district by approach district. The high east pass approach had three entries in the first register — a retaining wall repair, a drainage channel cleared, a section of the approach road resurfaced following a rock slide. Normal maintenance. She moved to the second register, a year earlier.

The high-approach infrastructure section had four entries. She read them in order and stopped at the third.

New vent shaft, high east pass approach, installed for thermal pressure regulation. Auth. Contractor: Guild of Binders, by authority of Founding Guildmaster Arvid Senne.

She read it twice. Then a third time.

The founding Guildmaster had commissioned a vent shaft in the high east pass approach in the year before the Great Wild Blaze. A vent shaft installed for thermal pressure regulation, in the same approach from which the city's own prefect watch had recorded the first smoke on the morning the Blaze began. In the same approach from which Kessel had watched the smoke rise at twelve years old, and from which she had spent sixty years assuming she'd been looking in the wrong direction.

She set the building register down on the shelf carefully, and stood still for a moment.

The connection she was holding had the quality of something almost complete — components aligned, shape visible, the last piece still not locked into position. The vent shaft, sixty years old, installed by the Guild's own founding Guildmaster. The thermal safety regulators in the hearth chamber, flush-mounted on the east wall, wheel handles worn dark from years of use, labelled with the same phrase — *thermal pressure regulation* — as if the language itself had been handed down intact from the original installation. The approach in her own binding that hadn't ranged or probed, that had come straight and purposeful at the contain-point. The fifteen years of fire origins on the east slope, the same three zones, year after year.

She could feel the connection closing. Not quite closed. Almost.

"What is it?" Kessel said.

"An entry in the building register," Priska said. Her voice came out level. "Year before the Blaze."

* * *

When she looked up from the shelf, Binder Reth was at the far end of the records room.

She had been focused on the building register and had not noticed him arrive. He was working through a different set of drawers — pulling a document, consulting it, replacing it — with the

even efficiency of someone doing routine administrative work. He was perhaps forty, lean and close-cropped in the way of someone who spent time outdoors and found it practical to be. Four Containment Marks were visible on his forearms where his sleeves were rolled, the branching well-established, the older ones beginning to silver at their edges.

His attention moved from the register she was holding to Kessel beside her. Then back to the register.

He said nothing.

He closed the drawer he'd been consulting, gathered the single document he'd removed for examination, and walked toward the door at the same pace he'd been moving through the work. Nothing about his departure communicated urgency. He finished what he was doing and left.

Priska looked at where he'd been standing. She placed his name from the Guild's approach-assignment board posted two days ago: Reth. Senior Binder Reth. Operational staff, Guildmaster's office.

The Guildmaster's operational staff ran the binding approaches. They did the season's field work. They did not, as a rule, cross-reference records with the civic administrative archive.

She replaced the building register on its shelf. "We should go," she said to Kessel.

* * *

The steps of the city records hall faced down the administrative district toward the lower pass, and from the top step she could see most of Kelmouth below — the city compact in its rock corridor, every roofline carrying its column of heat-shimmer up into the cold afternoon air.

Kessel had followed her out and stood beside her on the landing for a moment without speaking.

"Should I have said something?" Kessel said. "Years ago. When it might have mattered."

Priska thought about how to answer honestly. "You told a stranger over tea," she said. "That's not negligence. That's just remembering."

"I told Oren, too. He looked into it and came back and told me the Guild's account was thorough."

"He had no reason not to believe it himself."

Kessel was quiet for a moment. "No," she said. "He didn't." She seemed partially reassured by this — enough to carry the question rather than be knocked sideways by it, but not enough to put it down entirely. She went down the remaining steps and started back toward the lower pass district without looking back.

Priska watched her go.

Then she sat down on the top step and looked at the city.

The administrative district sat high enough on the pass that she could see the whole of Kelmouth laid out below — the rooflines descending in tiers toward the valley road, the containment hearth vents on each block exuding their thin heat-shimmer into the cold afternoon air. From up here the city looked the way it always looked: compact, stone-built, sensibly arranged within the constraints of the pass geography. The binders kept it warm. The hearths kept the aqueducts running. Everyone in Kelmouth understood this. The understanding was so complete and so long-established that it had stopped being understanding and had become simply the shape of the world.

She had been thinking precisely and methodically for three weeks. She had been testing every connection against the possibility that she was pattern-finding in coincidence, that she was a frightened second-year who had done her first solo binding and was constructing significance out of ordinary events. She had been holding herself to a standard she knew was the right one — not drawing conclusions before the evidence warranted them.

She let the standard go for a few minutes and looked at what she had.

The vent shaft in the high east pass approach, installed for thermal pressure regulation by the Guild's founding Guildmaster in the year before the Great Wild Blaze. The Blaze, which had started in the east pass — not the western brush — as confirmed by the city prefect's own watch records and by a twelve-year-old on a rooftop who had spent sixty years believing her memory was wrong. The Blaze, which had established the Guild's authority and given it the institutional standing to manage every fire season in Kelmouth for the six decades since.

The thermal safety regulators in the hearth chamber. Four of them, flush-mounted, iron, wheel handles worn dark from years of handling. The same phrase: thermal pressure regulation. The same system, intact.

The binding three weeks ago — the approach that hadn't ranged, hadn't probed, had come straight at the contain-point with the quality of something that already knew the path it was taking. Linear. Compressed. Nothing like what a wild spirit was supposed to be.

And the fifteen years of maps on her dormitory floor. The ignition origins on the east slope, the same three zones year after year, with just enough variation to look like natural scatter until you laid all fifteen at once and the pattern beneath became undeniable.

She sat with all of it.

The what was this: the fires were being started deliberately. Not by nature, not by the wild spirits' own movement through dry mountain terrain. The vent shaft was not a safety mechanism. The thermal safety regulators were not safety mechanisms. They were the mechanism — the means by which the Guild introduced directed heat into the mountain approach and produced what looked, to anyone watching from below, like the natural emergence of a wild-fire spirit. The Guild's own binders then contained the result. The city was grateful. The city had been grateful for sixty years, and the hearths had been full for sixty years, and the Guild had been funded and authorised and central to the city's survival for sixty years, and the arrangement was self-sustaining at every point.

She didn't yet understand why. She didn't know whether Ashe had designed this or inherited it, or how many Guildmasters had known, or whether the Blaze itself had been a first test that went further than intended or a deliberate founding act. She didn't know what the fires had cost in the years since — how many had burned hotter than they should have, how many people had been in the wrong place at the wrong moment in the wrong dry season.

Those things mattered. She would need to know them.

But she understood the what now, sitting on the steps of the city records hall looking at the heat-shimmer rising from every roofline in the city below her. Rising from hearths that were full. Hearths that her own hands had helped fill, three weeks ago, on the slope above the east pass approach.

Oh, she thought.

Not alarmed. Not angry. Not yet afraid.

Just: *oh.*

Chapter 5: The Pattern in the Hearth

She and Tobin had not spoken since the archive.

That was twelve days ago, and they had been in the same building, at the same meals in the senior apprentice mess, on the same assignment board for two minor-category fires in the week preceding this one. He had not avoided her and she had not avoided him. They had simply not spoken, which was an arrangement that could hold indefinitely if neither of them chose to disrupt it.

The fire call went out at second bell of the morning watch — smoke on the upper east approach, significant spread, full team required. Priska was assigned as secondary binder under Tobin's lead. The assignment board had been updated in the twenty minutes between the call going out and the teams assembling at the staging area on the approach road.

The east approach staging area was a rock-cut shelf two hundred feet above the Guild Hall gate, wide enough for four binders to hold containment positions without their approach lines overlapping. Tobin gave the position orders — primary contain-point, two secondary positions flanking at forty-foot intervals, a fall-back marker at the approach road's edge for the third binder in case the spread ran wide. He was efficient and precise. Priska took the right-of-centre secondary position, the contain-point marker forty feet south of his primary, and the team moved out along the approach road.

The fire was larger than the one she had bound alone six weeks ago. She could see it before she reached her position — the spirit's leading edge visible in the upper approach as a wide disturbance in the air above the scrub line, the heat shimmer buckling in a band rather than the concentrated shimmer of a smaller emergence. The scrub at this level was already past its tolerable threshold, the stems clicking in the heat, and the air coming down the pass had the specific quality it had in her first binding: char-before-burning, the smell of something organic at its limit.

She reached the contain-point marker, pressed her palms together, felt the channel points warm, and waited.

The spirit came from the east.

She felt its approach through the rock before the heat shimmer reached her position — the low resonance rising through the contain-point marker and into her soles, the same vibration she'd felt six weeks ago, now recognisable, now expected. She read the approach. The way it was or wasn't ranging. Whether it was probing to either side of the contain-point or coming straight. She read it the way she now read all approaches: not to confirm what she was supposed to find, but to check what was actually there.

The approach was the same as it had been in her first binding. Compressed. A single line of movement, the absolute absence of ranging. No probe-and-withdrawal when it registered her presence at the contain-point marker. No doubling-back, no lateral testing, no erratic pressure

from any direction except one. It came straight at her, at the intake pipe below her feet, at the hearth at the bottom of the shaft — with a quality she had spent six weeks trying to name correctly, and which she now named: *aimed*. Not a thing moving with its own will toward something it had found. A thing moving with the precision of something that had been directed at a target from a distance she couldn't see.

She was not calling it nerves.

She moved forward two steps, dropped her weight into her heels, pressed both palms flat against the scored stone of the intake cap. The channelling posture locked. Elbows, shoulders, feet.

The heat built higher than her first binding. The spirit pushed back against the contain-point with more force than she'd held before, the pressure sustained rather than peaking and dropping, the kind of extended hold that made the channel points ache and the Mark on her left wrist flare with a deep, radiating heat that ran up her forearm as the channelling held. Her vision narrowed at the edges. She kept her weight centred and did not move. She held through the pressure peak, through three minutes of cresting heat that ran longer than the first binding's, and felt the spirit exhaust into the intake at the normal time, the pressure dropping cleanly as the leading edge exhausted into the channel.

She stepped back. Dropped her arms. Breathed.

The Mark on her wrist was hot to the touch through her sleeve. She left her cuff down.

In the debrief at the staging area, Tobin noted the unusual spread rate, the higher containment pressure, the possibility of terrain factors worth surveying before the final seasonal binding. He ran through it precisely, invited observations from the other team members, noted everything in the ledger he carried for field work. The two other binders offered their own readings. Priska said nothing. She listened carefully to what Tobin recorded and noted that he described the approach as consistent with east-slope terrain bias, which was what the seasonal plan predicted.

She did not say what she'd felt.

* * *

She found him as the debrief broke up, before the team had fully dispersed back toward the Hall.

"Come and look at something," she said. Not a question. He looked at her for a moment — the specific look of someone who has been waiting for a conversation to begin without knowing when it would — and then he came.

The hearth chamber was empty in the mid-morning. The intake ceremony was weeks past, the seasonal work winding down, the hearths near their winter capacity. The chamber had its constant warmth, the low, even heat radiating from three full containment hearths, the sound of nothing except the deep settling of stored energy in stone.

She walked to the east wall and stopped in front of the nearest thermal safety regulator. Iron,

flush to the stone, wheel handle worn dark at the grip from years of use. The label above the wheel: *thermal safety regulator*. She'd noticed the row of them at the intake ceremony six weeks ago, crossed the room to read the nearest label, and filed it. She hadn't asked about them because there were always components she hadn't had explained yet, and the approach she'd found most useful was to wait for the context to arrive.

The context had arrived.

She turned to face Tobin. He was already looking at the valve, not at her.

She laid it out without flourish. Kessel's testimony first — east-pass smoke, sixty years ago, watched from a rooftop at the age of twelve all through the morning the Blaze began. The woman had been there. She'd watched the smoke column thicken for hours before her mother moved them down the mountain. She had stopped mentioning it over the years because the Guild's account didn't match it, and the Guild had documentation and witnesses and she had a rooftop. Priska had gone with Kessel to the city records hall six days ago and read the civic prefect's own first-sighting report. First confirmed smoke: high east pass, first bell. Not the western brush.

The four witnesses on the Guild's formal ignition determination. She'd searched for them across five separate ledger systems in the Guild's archive: binder rolls, intake records, cohort registers, seasonal assignment rosters, supplementary appendices for variant name spellings. None of the four appeared in any other Guild record. They had signed the most important founding document in the Guild's history and left no other institutional trace.

The building register entry from the city records hall. A vent shaft in the high east pass approach, registered in the year before the Blaze, installed for thermal pressure regulation, commissioned by the Guild's founding Guildmaster — she gave the name from the register: Arvid Senne. The same phrase as the label above the valve she was standing next to. The same system, sixty years old, intact.

The fifteen years of seasonal ignition maps. She described the work: pulling the maps from the current-records section, spreading them in her room, reading them year by year, noticing the consistency in the origin zones. The same three points on the east slope, season after season, with just enough variation to look like normal terrain bias until you stacked all fifteen at once and the underlying pattern became undeniable. She had laid a marked board over each map in sequence. The circles stacked.

And her own experience in two bindings: the same quality of approach in each. Compressed. Single-directional. The absolute absence of ranging. No probe-and-withdrawal. No doubling-back when the spirit registered her presence at the contain-point. It moved in a straight line at the intake pipe with the quality of something that had been aimed at a target from a position she couldn't see.

She had felt it again today. An hour ago, at the right-of-centre contain-point on the upper east approach, with Tobin twenty feet to her left at the primary position. She had recorded it as nerves the first time, six weeks ago. She was not recording it as nerves now.

She finished.

“Is anything I’m describing wrong?” she said.

Tobin was looking at the valve shaft. He had been looking at it since she’d started describing the witnesses, which was early in her account. He hadn’t looked at her directly, and he hadn’t interrupted. She could see the set of his jaw from this angle, the stillness of his shoulders — not the managed stillness she’d observed from him in the archive, where he’d arrived knowing the shape of a conversation and had handled it with deliberate composure. This was quieter than that.

He said: “Can I see the maps?”

She had them. She’d taken the seasonal ignition maps from the current-records section three days ago and hadn’t returned them. She unrolled the first five on the hearth chamber’s stone floor, weighted the corners with the water cups kept on the shelf beside the east wall, and stepped back.

Tobin crouched. He worked from the oldest to the most recent, studying the origin notation on each one, his attention moving between maps in the methodical sequence of someone who had been trained to read approach data and was now reading something that looked like approach data but meant something else. He stayed with the last two for longer than the others.

Then he stood.

He looked at the valve shaft again. The particular quiet that followed was not his archive quiet. It was the quiet of someone whose understanding of their own situation has just shifted significantly and who is working out what that means.

He said: “My uncle approved the last valve maintenance check himself. Three months ago.”

He said nothing else. He looked at her once — brief, direct, entirely unreadable — and walked out of the hearth chamber.

She stood where she was and listened to his footsteps cross the stone floor, the creak of the heavy door on its hinges, the silence after.

* * *

She stayed.

The hearth chamber settled into its ordinary quiet around her. The maps were still on the floor. She left them there and crossed to the valve shaft and rested her palm against the body of the mechanism — not the wheel handle but the iron cylinder itself, flush with the stone wall. It was warm. It had been warm every time she’d been in this room — she’d attributed it to the hearths, to the ambient heat of a room full of stored thermal energy. A reasonable attribution. A correct attribution, as far as it went. The hearth heat was real and the warmth was real. The mechanism

was also real. Both things true.

She counted backward from the final seasonal binding.

Nine days.

The final binding was the city's event — not the approach-line work that had continued all season on the upper mountain, but the formal public binding conducted in the city square at the season's close, the ceremony the city enacted with itself each year to mark the passage from dry season to cold season. The Guild opened the square-side hearth intake. The whole city came. The senior binders worked from a raised platform at the square's centre. The crowd stood three deep at the perimeter. It was ceremony and it was also the season's largest containment — the intake that brought the thermal reserve from summer surplus to winter sufficiency, the one binding where the stakes were visible to everyone, where the Guild's necessity was demonstrably, publicly real.

The spirit's approach, at the public binding, would be visible from the staging platform as a disturbance in the air above the square — the heat shimmer, the displacement. Anyone in the crowd could see that. What they couldn't see was what she could feel from the contain-point: the compression, the linear path, the complete absence of ranging that distinguished a directed approach from a wild one. That was something only a binder at close range could sense through the rock and through the channel points.

She needed to be on the perimeter. Secondary assignment put her in the approach line. That was close enough.

What she needed to make legible was the distinction between the approach that the crowd was watching and the approach that she was feeling — the difference between the visible shimmer and the invisible wrongness inside it. The shimmer looked the same whether the spirit had been directed or had moved on its own. There was no visible sign. The wrongness was entirely in the movement pattern, the quality of aim, the thing she could feel and not show.

She turned it over slowly.

She had the sensation clearly now. She had two bindings' worth of it, the physical description held precisely and consistently. She had the evidence chain — the documents, the maps, the testimony — that explained where the sensation came from and what it meant. What she didn't have was a way to make forty thousand people understand what she was feeling in the seconds before containment, in the middle of a ceremony, in front of a crowd that trusted what it was watching.

The valve shaft was warm under her palm. Steadily, evenly warm. The kind of warmth that had been there for sixty years and had never been remarked on because it had never been a question.

Nine days.

The shape of something was forming. Not a plan — too early for that, too many things still

unknown, Tobin's response and its implications still unresolved in the air of the room. But the shape of a direction. She knew where the binding would happen and she knew what she would feel there and she knew what she wanted to say while she felt it. The rest was a problem of position and access and timing and whether there was a way to make the invisible visible in a public space before the Guild completed the containment and the moment closed.

She stayed with the warm iron of the shaft under her palm and let the shape turn over.

Nine days.

Chapter 6: The Restricted Record

Tobin came at first light.

He knocked once. When she opened the door he was holding a folded document — a single sheet, pressed board, folded twice, with no marking on the outside. He held it out to her without preamble.

"This is the last one I can get without him knowing," he said.

She took it. He came inside and she closed the door.

She understood what he meant by *the last one*. The restricted secondary archive — the one she'd found a reference to in the Guild Hall index catalogue, the one requiring Guildmaster's authorisation for Guild personnel to access — was not a collection whose access log went unexamined. Someone who entered repeatedly, or who stayed long, or who pulled a document that seemed inconsistent with their usual work, would eventually be noticed. Someone who entered once, briefly, pulling a specific record, at an hour when the archive attendant might not be present, might not be. Tobin had taken that risk once. He could not take it again.

She didn't ask how he'd managed it. She didn't ask what he'd decided overnight between the hearth chamber and this morning, or what the deciding had felt like. He would not have answered those questions and the answers were not the point.

She unfolded the document at her writing board, smoothing the creases flat. Tobin stood near the window — not looking out, just standing, giving her room to read.

The document was a maintenance log for the valve shaft network on the upper east approach. A continuous record, a single long sheet that had been added to by successive Guildmasters across several decades — she could see the handwriting change at each new entry, different pens, different hands, the slight variation in the Guild's formal notation style as the decades changed. Some entries were larger and more expansive; others compressed and brief. The sheet itself had been extended with additional vellum at some point — there was a seam in the material two-thirds of the way down where an older document had been extended to make room for more entries, the join reinforced with careful stitching. It was the institutional equivalent of a conversation being passed from one person to the next, each adding their contribution and handing it on, the accumulated record of something being maintained across several lifetimes.

She read it from the oldest entry forward.

The early entries were purely technical: dates, inspection records, pressure readings, notations about specific components. In the fourteenth year after the Blaze, someone had repaired a shaft seal on the third valve station — the entry described the repair method in detail, in the manner of someone documenting it for whoever came next. In the twenty-second year: the valve housing cleaned and regreased, the wheel handle mechanisms checked, all four stations confirmed functioning. In the thirty-first year: no issues noted, annual inspection complete, minor corrosion treated at junction point of valve two and valve three.

The language was consistent across all of them. Technical, specific, the record of someone maintaining a piece of infrastructure with care. Nothing in any of the early entries indicated what the infrastructure was for. She read the component descriptions and the inspection outcomes and the occasional notation about repair work, and each one looked exactly like what it claimed to be: a maintenance record for a component of the hearth system.

She stopped at the entry from Ashe's predecessor.

The handwriting was tighter than Ashe's, more compressed, with the particular economy of someone who wrote quickly and disliked waste. The entry was dated approximately twenty-three years before the current season. It read:

High east approach shaft system: seasonal inspection completed. Pressure integrity confirmed at all four valve stations. Controlled ignition via release valve: executed without incident. Thermal distribution to intake channel: nominal.

She read it twice. Then she read the specific phrase again.

Controlled ignition.

Not *release*. Not *event*. Not *pressure discharge*.

Ignition. The correct technical term for deliberately starting a fire.

Whoever had written this entry had not been careful about euphemism. They had written down what the mechanism actually did, using the word that accurately described it, in the same tone they'd used to record the pressure readings and the valve housing condition. It was in there the way anything was in there — as a technical fact, recorded alongside other technical facts, filed in a restricted archive that required Guildmaster's authorisation to access.

Tobin had moved from the window. He was reading over her shoulder now, close enough that she was aware of the specific quality of his attention — not reading casually, reading the way he'd read the ignition maps in the hearth chamber, with the focused precision of someone extracting the exact meaning from each word.

She moved to Ashe's entry. It was dated eighteen years prior, early in his tenure. The handwriting was his — she recognised it from the assignment board and from the seasonal records she'd read in the archive.

High east approach shaft system: full review conducted. All components inspected. System maintained at current protocol.

No mention of ignition. No operational language at all. The entry read like a cleaning record, a note that the thing had been looked at and found satisfactory. The word *protocol* did the work of covering what the protocol actually was.

"His predecessor used the operational language," Priska said. "He changed it."

"Yes," Tobin said.

She set the document down on the writing board. They were both standing, and for a moment neither of them said anything. The first bell of the morning watch rang distantly from the city below.

“Write it down,” she said.

She got the second sheet of pressed board she kept for study notes. She set it in front of her and began to write. Tobin watched for a moment, then pulled the chair closer and sat. She wrote and he read as she wrote, and when she paused he said nothing, which she understood as confirmation that what she was recording was accurate.

The list:

1. Widow Kessel — east-pass smoke, morning of the Great Wild Blaze, watched from rooftop, consistent with city prefect’s first-sighting report.

2. City prefect’s record — first confirmed smoke, high east pass, first bell. Filed at city records hall. Inconsistent with Guild’s formal determination of ignition point: western brush.

3. Four witnesses on Guild ignition determination (names: Beren Calt, Ossin Marke, Devin Ashel, Pren Wollam) — no trace in binder rolls, intake records, cohort registers, seasonal assignments, or supplementary appendices. Appear in no other Guild document.

4. City building register — vent shaft, high east pass approach, installed for thermal pressure regulation, year before the Blaze, commissioned by Founding Guildmaster Arvid Senne.

5. Seasonal ignition maps, current decade: fifteen years, same three zones on east slope, degree of variation consistent with deliberate variation rather than natural scatter.

6. Sensory record — two bindings, upper east approach: compressed, single-directional, non-ranging approach in both. Consistent with directed spirit movement, not wild.

7. Maintenance log, high east approach shaft system — predecessor’s entry: “controlled ignition via release valve: executed without incident.” Ashe’s entry: “system reviewed and maintained at current protocol.”

She set the pen down.

They both looked at the list for a moment. Seven items. Point by point. Written in her hand on pressed board. It was not comfortable to look at. She’d been holding each piece separately for weeks, had understood them individually and had understood them together from the steps of the city records hall. Seeing them written in sequence — numbered, each one specific and sourced — made something different of them. Made the thing they described concrete and named and unable to be unmade by looking away.

Tobin said: “Three months ago he approved the valve maintenance himself. Not through the operational staff. Personally.”

“Yes.”

“Which means he knew the final seasonal binding was next.” A pause. “Which means he was preparing it.”

“Yes.”

Neither of them said anything for a moment. The first bell had moved to second bell while she’d been writing; she could hear the distant toll of it from the city below, the sound that meant the morning watch was changing.

She looked at the list again. On paper it was not an argument, not a theory — it was a series of documented facts that each had a source and a location and a specific gap between what they said and what the Guild’s official account said. You could not dismiss any individual item without addressing it specifically. You could not dismiss all seven at once.

“There are things this list doesn’t prove,” she said. “It doesn’t show the deaths. It doesn’t show how far back it goes or how many Guildmasters knew. It doesn’t show what happened to any binder who noticed before me.”

“No,” Tobin said.

“But it shows what the mechanism is. It shows where it started. It shows that the language in the maintenance log uses the word *ignition* and the Guild’s public account says *wild fire*. Anyone who can read can see that gap.”

Tobin said nothing. He was looking at the list.

* * *

“What are you going to do with it?” Tobin said.

“The final seasonal binding,” she said. “The city square. The whole city watching.”

He looked at her.

“I need to be on the binding perimeter,” she said. “Secondary position, which puts me at the contain-point for the square-side intake. Close enough to feel the spirit’s approach before the lead binder completes the containment. Close enough to read it the same way I’ve read it on the mountain approaches.” She paused, then continued, because he needed to hear the full logic of it: “The heat shimmer and air displacement are visible to anyone — the crowd will see the approach. What they won’t see is what I feel from the contain-point: the compression, the linear path, the absence of ranging. That’s the difference between a wild spirit and a directed one, and it’s invisible without a binder at close range to read it. But if I describe it aloud, while it’s happening — name the sensation in plain language while the crowd is watching the shimmer — I’m translating the invisible evidence into testimony. I’m not asking the crowd to believe something they can’t verify. I’m telling them what to look for in the documents they can find, while I demonstrate the mechanism in the act of doing what I was trained to do.”

She stopped. She'd said more than she usually said at once. Tobin's expression hadn't changed, which she'd found was a useful indicator — when he disagreed he showed it, not in his face but in a specific quality of stillness that was different from his ordinary stillness.

He wasn't showing it now. He was simply looking at the list.

"That's not a plan," he said. "That's a hope."

"I know."

"Getting from secondary position on the east approach team to the city square perimeter isn't the same as your approach-line work. The public binding uses a platform, crowd stewards, a controlled perimeter. You'd need to be authorised to be at the contain-point in the square, not just on the mountain."

"I know," she said again.

He looked at the list on her writing board. Then at the maintenance log beside it. Then at the assignment board she kept pinned to the wall above her writing board — the current-season assignments, updated each time the board in the main corridor was changed.

She followed his look.

Tobin Ashe: lead binder, city square final binding. Nine days.

Priska Emberlyn: secondary, city square final binding. Nine days.

She hadn't noticed the update. The assignments had been moved — the mountain approach teams stood down for the season, the city square binding the last remaining event. She and Tobin were both on it. The same platform, the same perimeter, the same contained space where the whole city would be watching.

Secondary position at the city square binding was the contain-point. The same role she'd held on the approach. Close enough to feel the spirit's movement. Close enough to read the approach before the lead binder completed the containment.

Close enough.

Tobin was looking at the board. He wasn't looking at her. He said nothing about what the assignment meant for the plan she'd described — the plan that was not yet a plan.

"Secondary is enough," she said quietly. Not to him, or not only to him. "If I know what I'm doing."

He left the maintenance log on her writing board and walked out without commenting on what she'd said. She heard the door close, his footsteps recede down the corridor, and then the return of the morning silence.

She looked at the assignment board for a while. *Nine days* written in small, neat notation beside the date. It was enough time for the Guild to prepare the square, rig the perimeter, build the

staging platform, and ensure forty thousand people would be standing exactly where the Guild wanted them. It was enough time for Corvain Ashe to ensure the thermal mechanism in the east pass was primed and ready to deliver a compressed, directed ignition to the city.

It was also enough time for her to prepare.

She didn't know yet how she would handle the crowd stewards, or what the institutional penalty would be when she broke protocol. She didn't know what Tobin would do when she stepped into his primary containment field. But the shape of the thing was set. The mechanism was real, the documents were in her room, and the assignment board had put her exactly where she needed to be.

She took the restricted maintenance log and carefully folded it back along its original creases. She placed it beneath the pressed board containing her numbered list, squared the edges of both so they sat perfectly aligned on the center of her writing desk, and left them there.

Then she began to get ready for her day.

Chapter 7: The Eve of the Final Binding

The summons came at eighth bell, long after the administrative offices usually closed.

The messenger who knocked on her door was a first-year apprentice who looked nervous to be delivering it. “The Guildmaster,” he said, standing rigidly in the corridor. “In his office.”

Priska did not ask what it was about. She put on her formal Guild jacket, the one required for administrative meetings, checked that the cuffs were pulled down over the Containment Mark on her left wrist, and walked up the three flights of stairs to the executive level.

Tomorrow was the final seasonal binding. The city square was already rigged, the perimeter lines drawn in chalk and rope, the staging platform built over the square-side intake. She had spent the last eight days holding the shape of what she intended to do, waiting for the moment to arrive.

Corvain Ashe’s office was at the end of the hall. The door was heavy, dark wood, and it was open.

“Emberlyn,” Ashe said as she stopped in the doorway. “Come in. Shut the door.”

She did. The office was not a ceremonial space. It was a working room, dominated by a large table covered in topographical maps of the mountain passes, deployment schedules, and intake capacity reports. Ashe sat behind the desk, surrounded by the mechanical administration of the city’s survival. He was in his fifties, a man who had spent the better part of twenty years in the field before inheriting the administration of it. When he rolled his sleeves up, as he had now, the eight Containment Marks on his forearms were visible — a dense, branching lattice of silvered scars that spoke of massive thermal exposure, managed and survived.

He did not look like a monster. He looked tired, efficient, and thoroughly embedded in his responsibilities.

“Tomorrow is your first public binding,” Ashe said. He was looking at a personnel ledger, not at her. “Secondary position. It’s a significant assignment for a second-year.”

“Yes, Guildmaster.”

“You’ve had a fast season. A solo containment on the upper approach, followed by a high-pressure dual containment with my nephew.” He closed the ledger and finally looked at her. His eyes were pale, observant, and completely steady. “How are you finding the work?”

She kept her voice level. “I noticed the pressure requires sustained channelling. But the mechanics are what we were taught.” She used the exact phrase she always used. *I noticed.* The safe, observational language of an apprentice.

Ashe studied her for a moment. “The mechanics,” he repeated. “Yes. The mechanics are reliable. That is the entire point of the Guild, Emberlyn. Reliability.”

He stood up and walked to the large map table. He looked down at the topography of Kelmouth

and the mountain passes above it.

“Before the Blaze, the fire season was a terror,” Ashe said. His tone was conversational, almost academic. The tone of a man discussing structural engineering. “Every dry season, the city looked east and wondered if this was the year the wind would change and take the residential district. The mountain was chaotic. Unpredictable. And unpredictability is what kills people. Do you understand that?”

“Yes, Guildmaster.”

“The founding Guildmaster understood it. Arvid Senne.” He said the name deliberately, letting it sit in the quiet air of the office. Priska did not react. “Senne understood that you cannot build a permanent city on a foundation of chance. If you wait for a wild spirit to decide when and where it will strike, you are reacting. And reaction is where accidents happen. Reaction is where containment fails.”

He traced a line on the map with his index finger. The line of the high east pass approach, running down toward the residential blocks.

“To manage a risk perfectly,” Ashe said, “you have to control the variables. You remove the unpredictability. You deliver the threat on a schedule you control, to a location you have prepared for, into an intake you have already opened. You give the city a managed outcome.” He lifted his hand from the map and looked at her, his expression carrying the weight of decades of administrative burden. “They call it salvation, but it isn’t. It’s just stewardship. We steward the city’s safety. We ensure the aqueducts don’t freeze, the bakehouses don’t fail, and the residential districts don’t burn. We do it efficiently, year after year, and the cost of that efficiency is that we do not allow variables to disrupt the delivery.”

He paused, letting the silence in the room thicken. The ambient heat from the lower hearths hummed through the floorboards.

“Sometimes,” Ashe continued softly, “stewardship requires decisions that look complex, or even unpalatable, from the outside. But from the inside, they are very simple. A system that keeps forty thousand people alive cannot afford to indulge the unpredictable. It cannot afford components that fail to execute their assigned function.”

He looked up from the map. The subtext in the room was so dense it was almost physical, pressing against her ears like a change in atmospheric pressure. He was not confessing to a crime. He was explaining the philosophy of the machine. He was telling her that the manufactured fires were an architectural necessity, and that he genuinely believed the city was better off living in a managed fiction than dying in an unmanaged reality.

He was also telling her that he knew exactly what she had found, and that she was now a variable.

“The public binding is different from the approach work,” Ashe said, moving back to his desk. “The crowd adds pressure. The spirit behaves exactly as it always behaves, but the binder sometimes forgets their training under the eyes of forty thousand people. They break posture.

They panic."

"I understand," Priska said.

"I hope you do," Ashe said quietly. "Tomorrow is the pinnacle of our consistency. I need you to be perfectly consistent tomorrow, Priska. Do your job exactly as you were trained to do it, and you will be safe."

He picked up his pen. The meeting was over.

"Thank you, Guildmaster," she said.

She turned and walked out of the office. She closed the heavy door behind her and walked down the corridor, keeping her pace steady, her breathing controlled. She did not let the adrenaline spike until she was in the stairwell, out of sight of the executive floor.

He knew. The entire conversation was a pressure test to see if she would break, and a warning of what would happen if she didn't align.

She reached the apprentice dormitory level and walked quickly to her room. She needed to get the list. She needed to find Tobin. If Ashe was delivering warnings disguised as philosophy, the timeline had collapsed. They couldn't wait for tomorrow. They had to take the maintenance log to the city prefect tonight.

She opened her door.

The air in the room was wrong.

It was a subtle thing, the kind of displacement you only notice in a space you inhabit daily. The dust motes in the shaft of moonlight from the window were swirling in a pattern that meant someone had moved through them recently.

She walked to the writing board.

The surface was empty.

The pressed board with her numbered, seven-point list of evidence was gone. The restricted maintenance log she had folded and placed beneath it was gone.

She stood perfectly still. The search had been entirely professional. Nothing was broken. Her bedclothes were undisturbed, the heavy wool blankets folded exactly as she had left them. Her spare uniform still hung precisely on its hook, the sleeves hanging straight. Her water cup sat on the shelf exactly where she always kept it.

There was no vandalism, no message scrawled on the wall, no theatrical violence. It was a surgical removal of the only things in the room that mattered, executed by someone who knew exactly what they were looking for and exactly how to leave the rest of her life untouched. The silence in the room felt heavy, watched.

She dropped to her knees. The stone floor was cold through the fabric of her trousers. She

reached under the bed, felt for the slight misalignment in the floorboards she had carefully engineered weeks ago, and pulled the loose plank free. She reached into the cavity beneath.

Empty.

The fifteen years of seasonal ignition maps, the visual proof of the controlled pattern she had overlaid and stacked, had been taken as well.

She sat back on her heels, leaving the floorboard resting on the stone. The physical sensation of the loss was sudden and sharp, a cold hollowing out of her chest that made it difficult to draw a full breath. The list was not just a piece of paper. It was the concrete reality of what she had discovered, the anchor that proved she wasn't pattern-finding in the dark. The maintenance log was the only piece of institutional proof that carried the word *ignition*, the only document that stripped away the euphemism. And the maps were the undeniable geometry of the system.

Without them, she had nothing. No paper. No witnesses. No proof. She had only a theory, and a tactile sensation in her hands that only she could feel, trapped inside a mechanism that the entire city believed in. The evidence chain was broken, swept clean while Ashe kept her occupied with philosophy three floors above.

She stood up. She had to find Tobin. If Ashe's people had searched her room, they had searched his.

She opened her door and stepped into the corridor.

Tobin was standing in the shadows at the end of the hall, near the stairwell. He stepped out as she emerged. He was not wearing his formal jacket; he was in his undershirt and braces, his face drawn tight, the muscles in his jaw locked.

He didn't speak. He just gestured for her to follow him.

They went down the stairs in silence, bypassing the apprentice levels, moving down to the main ground-floor corridor where the seasonal assignment board was kept. The corridor was empty at this hour, lit only by the low ambient glow of the wall sconces.

Tobin stopped in front of the board and pointed.

Priska looked at the final seasonal binding roster. It had been updated since she checked it this morning. The names had been changed, written in the crisp, administrative chalk of the Guildmaster's operational staff.

Lead Binder: Senior Binder Reth.

Secondary Binder: Apprentice Priska Emberlyn.

Tobin's name was gone. Not just moved to a secondary position, but erased from the event entirely.

"He called me in an hour ago," Tobin said. His voice was low, stripped of its usual careful

neutrality. It sounded like a wire pulled to the breaking point. “Said I was showing signs of thermal fatigue. Said the public binding requires a fresh rotation. He grounded me for the rest of the season.”

Priska stared at the board. Reth. A senior operational binder she knew mostly by sight, the man Ashe sent when a field job needed to go exactly to schedule. Four heavy containment marks and a quiet, efficient way of moving.

“My room was searched,” Priska said, not looking away from the names. “The list is gone. The maps. The maintenance log.”

“I know,” Tobin said. “He has the log. Which means he knows I pulled it from the restricted archive.”

“Why didn’t he pull me from the board?” she asked. The question was genuine, a mechanical problem she was trying to solve. If Ashe knew she had the evidence, and knew she was the one compiling it, grounding her would be the safest administrative move. Erase her from the public eye.

Tobin looked at her. In the dim light of the corridor, she saw the reality of the situation hit him, the same cold realization that was currently expanding in her own chest.

“Because he didn’t need to,” Tobin said softly. “Look at the roster, Priska. He put Reth on Lead.”

She looked at the board. Then she remembered Ashe’s words in the office, ten minutes ago. *The spirit behaves exactly as it always behaves, but the binder sometimes forgets their training… They break posture. They panic.*

“If a second-year binder panics during the public containment,” Tobin said, voicing the exact mechanism of the trap, “and breaks her channel posture, the spirit breaches the contain-point. It’s a massive thermal event. The Lead binder is forced to recover the breach to save the crowd. In the process, the second-year who caused the breach is consumed. It’s a tragedy. A reminder of the dangers of wild spirits.”

The shape of the thing clicked into place. It was not a plan, it was an execution.

Reth was not there to back her up. Reth was there to ensure that when the spirit struck the contain-point, the pressure would not be shared. He would let the spirit overwhelm her, let her burn, and then step in to contain it for the crowd. Ashe would stand on the platform and eulogize her sacrifice. The loose end would be incinerated inside the very mechanism she was trying to expose.

“You can’t go up there tomorrow,” Tobin said. He gripped her arm, his fingers digging into the heavy fabric of her jacket. “Refuse the assignment. Take the insubordination charge. They’ll expel you from the Guild, but you’ll be alive.”

Priska looked at the board.

Secondary Binder: Apprentice Priska Emberlyn.

Without the list, without the log, without the maps, she had no evidence to take to the prefect. If she refused the assignment and was expelled, she would be a disgraced apprentice with a wild conspiracy theory. Ashe would continue. The fires would continue. The machine would keep turning, flawlessly, for another sixty years.

Her hope of using the public binding to narrate the evidence was dead. She had no evidence to point to. The crowd would just see a frantic apprentice shouting about invisible things before a tragedy occurred.

She was completely isolated. The darkest moment of the season had arrived, and it smelled like chalk dust and old stone.

“If I refuse,” she said, “who takes secondary tomorrow?”

Tobin stared at her. “Does it matter? Someone who isn’t a threat to him.”

“Someone who doesn’t know what’s coming out of that vent,” Priska said. She pulled her arm gently out of his grip. “Someone who thinks it’s a wild spirit, and who won’t be braced for a directed impact.”

She looked back at her name on the board.

“I’m not refusing the assignment,” she said.

“Priska, it’s a closed system. You have no proof. You have no leverage. Reth will let you burn.”

“I know,” she said. She turned away from the board and started walking back toward the stairwell. “I need to get some sleep. Tomorrow is going to be a long day.”

She left him standing in the corridor.

As she climbed the stairs back to her empty, searched room, the terror she had been holding at bay finally seeped in. Ashe was right about one thing. Unpredictability was terrifying. But as she reached her door and put her hand on the handle, she realized he was wrong about another.

He thought he had removed all the variables.

He hadn’t.

Chapter 8: The Square-Side Intake

She dressed in the dark.

The Guild's formal binding uniform was heavy, woven from treated wool designed to resist flash-heat, stiff with the accumulated starch of ceremonial preparation. Priska put it on methodically. The trousers, the heavy boots, the thick undershirt, the jacket. She stood by the narrow window of her dormitory room and fastened the brass toggles up the front of the jacket, her fingers moving with the rhythm of someone completing a drill.

She pulled the left cuff down over her wrist. The Containment Mark lay hidden beneath the dark wool, grey-black and settled, cool against her skin.

Some time after the night's last bell she had gone down one flight and knocked on Tobin's door. He had opened it fully dressed, as if he had not tried to sleep either. She had said one thing to him, about the row of iron wheels on the east wall of the hearth chamber, the ones labelled *thermal safety regulator*, and about the watch horns, and about how long a spirit took to come down the avenue once the horns had sounded. He had not answered. She had not waited for him to. She had gone back upstairs and lain on top of the blankets with her boots beside the bed, and she did not know, now, fastening the last toggle, whether she had asked him for anything at all.

When she stepped out into the corridor, the apprentice levels were already empty. The city had been awake since before dawn. The final seasonal binding was the axis on which Kelmouth turned, the day the dry season officially ended and the cold season began, underwritten by the thermal reserve the Guild was about to lock into the square-side hearth.

She walked down the stairs, out the heavy oak doors of the Guild Hall, and into the streets.

The crowd was immense. The city had poured down from the residential tiers, filling the avenues, packing the balconies, lining the sloped roofs that overlooked the administrative district. Forty thousand people pressing inward toward the central square. Guild stewards in grey sashes managed the perimeter, holding the crush of bodies back behind rope barriers to keep the central avenue clear for the spirit's approach.

The noise was low and constant — anticipation, nervous energy, the collective breath of a city waiting to be kept warm.

Priska moved through the designated Guild channels, the crowd parting to let a binder in uniform pass. She felt their eyes on her. To them she was a part of the thing that kept them alive. They looked at the heavy jacket and the serious set of her jaw and saw the Guild's promise with a face on it.

She reached the central square.

The staging platform was a broad structure of iron and fire-treated timber, built directly over the square-side intake. The intake itself was a circle of black iron thirty feet across, capped at its centre with scored stone, dropping down into the largest containment hearth in the city network.

Priska climbed the wooden stairs to the deck.

Senior Binder Reth was already there, standing near the primary contain-point marker, checking the tension on his heavy leather gloves. He looked up as she approached. In the flat morning light his face was entirely calm. There was no malice in it, no sign that he knew what the day was meant to cost her. He was an operational man preparing for a complex piece of field work.

“Emberlyn,” Reth said. A professional acknowledgment.

“Senior Binder Reth.” Her voice did not shake.

He nodded once, then looked up toward the observation tier at the back of the platform. Priska followed his gaze.

Corvain Ashe stood at the railing of the raised tier in the formal mantle of the Guildmaster, the trim catching the morning light. He was looking out over the square, at the forty thousand people who had come to watch the Guild do what it had always done. He looked down at the deck, his eyes touching Reth, then Priska. A brief, solemn nod.

A brass bell sounded from the city prefect’s tower. First bell of the morning watch.

The crowd’s noise dropped in pitch and tightened into silence.

From the high eastern pass, the watch horns blew. A single long note that echoed down the stone corridor of the valley.

“Approach sighted,” Reth said quietly, stepping to the primary marker. “Take your position, Secondary.”

Priska walked to the secondary contain-point, fifteen feet to Reth’s right, a scored line in the stone where the intake cap met the iron.

She looked up the central avenue, toward the east pass.

The heat shimmer was visible even from here — a buckling in the air, a rippling lens of displaced atmosphere moving down the slope toward the city. A murmur went through the square, awe and old fear together. To anyone watching, it was a wild spirit coming down from the dry brush, as it had come every season of their lives.

Priska watched it come. She counted, because counting was a thing her body could do while the rest of her waited. She had told Tobin how long. She did not know if he had been listening.

The spirit behaves exactly as it always behaves, Ashe had said. *But the binder sometimes forgets their training. They break posture. They panic.*

The shimmer came down the last stretch of the avenue in a line so straight it could have been ruled. The air on the platform grew hot. The wood under her boots warmed through the soles.

She moved forward two steps — close enough — dropped her weight into her heels, and pressed

both palms flat against the scored stone of the intake cap.

Elbows locked. Shoulders dropped and pulled back. Feet spread to the width of the marker.

The same posture as her first binding, on the upper approach, with Ferath ten feet behind her and the sky the colour of ash. The same stone under her hands. The same heat building at the channel points at the base of each thumb.

And in the two or three seconds before full contact, when she was still reading the spirit rather than holding it, she felt it exactly as she had felt it twice before.

Linear. Compressed. No ranging to either side of the contain-point. No probe and withdrawal when it registered her presence. It came straight at her, at the intake, with the quality of something that already knew the path it was taking.

It was aimed.

The leading edge struck the contain-point.

The pressure drove into her palms and up her arms. It was far larger than anything she had held on the mountain, and it did not divide. To her left, Reth had stepped half a pace off his marker. His posture was correct. His hands were ready. They were not on the stone. The whole load of the spirit came into her channel and nowhere else, and she understood, with a clarity that felt almost like calm, that this was the moment she was supposed to break.

She did not break. She had been trained by a man who stood ten feet back on purpose. She held.

And while she held, she spoke.

“It is not ranging.”

Her voice came out louder than she had known she could make it, flattened by the heat, carried by the stone of the square. The front rows heard it. She saw faces turn.

“A wild spirit ranges,” she said. “It probes. It doubles back when it meets resistance. Every binder in this city was taught that in their first week. Watch the shimmer. You watched it come down the avenue. Did it turn once? It came in a straight line from the high east pass, because it was sent from the high east pass.”

The heat pressed her backward. She kept her weight in her heels.

“There is a vent shaft in the high east pass. It is in the city building register. It was installed the year before the Great Wild Blaze, by the Founding Guildmaster, for thermal pressure regulation. The city prefect’s own report of the Blaze puts the first smoke in the east pass. The Guild’s account says the western brush. Widow Kessel watched the smoke from her rooftop when she was twelve years old. She saw it in the east.” Her arms were shaking. She let them shake and kept them locked. “The Guild’s maintenance log for that shaft uses the words *controlled ignition*. I have read it. Go to the city records hall. The register is there. The prefect’s report is there. You do not need to believe me. You need to read.”

Her words went back through the square the way news always went through Kelmouth, mouth to ear, row to row. She could hear it happening behind the barriers, a sound like wind moving through dry scrub.

“Nature does not build straight lines,” she said, more quietly, because she had no breath left for anything louder.

On the observation tier, Ashe had begun to speak. She could hear his voice, measured and carrying, the voice of a man who had addressed the city every season for eighteen years. She could not make out his words over the roar of the heat.

Then the spirit changed under her hands.

The compression went out of it. She felt the push behind it falter, the way a current slackens when a sluice upstream is shut, and for a moment the pressure in her channel dropped so suddenly that she nearly pitched forward onto the cap. Then the spirit did what wild things do. It ranged.

It pulled off the contain-point to the left, probing along the iron rim of the intake toward the crowd barrier. It doubled back. It tested the edge of the platform, withdrew, came at the cap from a new angle. The shimmer, which had come down the avenue as a single ruled line, swung and branched and wandered over the square like water finding its way through broken ground.

Forty thousand people had just watched it come straight. Now they watched it range. The difference needed no one to explain it. The murmur behind the barriers stopped. The stewards stood with their arms out and did not move.

Somewhere above her, in the hearth chamber of the Guild Hall, someone had turned a row of iron wheels.

The spirit was not dangerous at this size, not yet, but a ranging spirit near a packed crowd had one safe place to go, and that was the intake. Priska kept her palms on the stone and felt for it — where it wasn’t going, as much as where it was — and found the next contain-point it would pass nearest, and was already there.

“Reth,” she said.

He was staring at the shimmer. His face had lost its operational calm. For a second she did not know which way he would move.

Then he stepped back onto the primary marker and pressed his palms to the stone.

The load divided. The pressure in her arms halved at once, and the relief of it was so sharp it was almost pain. Reth’s posture was flawless. Whatever he had been told to do that morning, he was a senior binder with four heavy marks, and a ranging spirit was the thing he had spent his life learning to contain. Between the two contain-points the spirit found its path of least resistance and took it, down through their hands and into the intake and down into the hearth under the square. The heat crested, and dropped, and was gone.

She was standing with her arms still locked, her ears ringing, her palms pressed against stone that was merely warm.

She stepped back. Dropped her arms. Breathed.

Her left wrist burned. She did not need to look to know what it was. The branching of her first Mark had not stopped at the wrist; she could feel new heat running up the inside of her forearm, generating, settling, the way it had on the upper approach. A second Mark, earned on a spirit that had been sent to the square to break her. It was real. The fire behind it was not.

The square was entirely silent.

Not the traditional roar of gratitude that ended every final binding. Not panic. The heavy, attentive silence of a great many people who have just seen something they cannot unsee, and are waiting to learn what it means.

On the observation tier, Corvain Ashe stopped speaking.

He came down from the tier. He did not hurry. He crossed the deck of the platform with the same composure he had carried into every ceremony she had ever watched, the mantle straight on his shoulders, and he stopped in front of her, close enough that she could see the grey in his eyebrows and the fine lines of old marks running out of his cuffs.

“You don’t understand what you’ve done,” he said. He said it quietly, for her.

“I understand what you’ve done,” Priska said, at the same volume. “And now so does everyone here.”

He looked at her for a long moment. Then he looked past her, at the crowd behind the barriers — at the faces on the balconies and the roofs, at the stewards with their arms still raised, at the people in the front rows who had heard every word — and whatever he had meant to say next, he did not say it.

At the edge of the platform, near the stairs, a figure pushed past the stunned stewards.

Tobin.

He was out of uniform, in civilian clothes, his chest heaving as if he had run the whole way down from the Guild Hall. The palms of his hands were dark with old grease, the kind that coated the regulator wheels in the hearth chamber. He stopped at the edge of the deck and looked at Priska, at the scorched cuff of her sleeve, at the intake, and then up at his uncle.

Priska remembered the archive, weeks ago, and what Tobin had said to her between the shelves when she first asked him where the fires came from. *The hearth needs filling before it matters where the fire comes from.*

Across the platform, his eyes met hers. He did not say anything. He did not need to.

Ashe stood in the centre of the platform with the crowd pressing in against the ropes on every

side. Below him, the bound heat was already moving through the intake into the hearth, the way it did every year, the way it would have to do every year after this. The hearth would be full. The city would be warm for the winter.

Ashe looked at Priska once more. He said nothing.

The city was waiting.

It mattered exactly where the fire came from.

Chapter 9: The Reform Year

Three weeks after the final binding, Priska stood in the Guild's practice yard with six first-year apprentices and a bucket of cold water.

The yard sat on the lee side of the Guild Hall, out of the worst of the wind, a square of packed earth and scored stone markers where every binder in Kelmouth had learned to stand. The first-years had been there since second bell. Their breath showed in the air. The dry season was over, and the cold had come down the pass the way it did every year, sudden and total, a door shut on the summer.

"Again," Priska said.

She tipped a thin stream of water from the bucket onto the slope of the practice ramp, and it ran down the grooves cut in the stone, branching where the grooves branched, pooling and spilling and finding its way around the small obstacles set into the channel. Then she took the wooden trough from beside the ramp, set it in place, and poured again. The water ran straight down the trough and off the end in a single line.

"Which one is wild?" she said.

Six hands pointed at the ramp.

"Why?"

A boy near the back said, "Because it goes where it wants."

"No," Priska said. "Neither of them wants anything. The ramp water goes where the ground lets it go. It tests. It turns back when it meets a stone. The trough water has already been told. Your hands will feel that difference before your eyes do, if you learn to pay attention to it. That is what you are practising. Not the posture. The paying attention."

She had been asked to add it to the curriculum eight days after the binding, in a short letter signed by Ferath and countersigned by an inspector from the city assembly whose name she did not know. The letter had not called it a reform. It had called it an amendment to second-term instruction. She had written back the same day and said yes.

Nobody had written the lesson down yet. She was writing it as she taught it, in the evenings, on pressed board, in a list that looked a great deal like another list she had once kept on her writing board. She tried not to think about that too often.

"Again," she said, and the first-years bent over the ramp.

* * *

Tobin came into the yard a little before fourth bell. He was in Guild uniform again, a plain working jacket without any of the ceremonial trim, and he had a sheaf of hearing notes under one

arm. He waited at the edge of the yard until she dismissed the apprentices, and then he came over and stood beside the practice ramp and looked at the water freezing in its grooves.

“They read the findings today,” he said.

“Tell me.”

He did not look at the notes. He had them by heart, the way he had everything by heart.

“Forty-seven years,” he said. “Continuous, scheduled ignitions from the high east pass. Three Guildmasters. It began under the one before my uncle’s predecessor. The shaft was older than that — Senne built it — but the assembly couldn’t find anything to show what Senne meant it for, so they left that open. They didn’t leave the rest open.” He paused. “Eleven deaths. They named them. Every one. The dates, the district, the binding. Four binders, seven people who were in the wrong street when a containment failed. All of them recorded at the time as losses to wild fire. The assembly has reclassified every one of them as a death caused by the Guild.”

Priska looked at the water in the grooves.

Eleven. She had known there would be a number. She had written *It doesn’t show the deaths* on her own list, weeks ago, and had understood even then that the gap in the list was a gap that would be filled by someone. It was different to hear the number in a voice. Eleven families who had been told their people died so the city could live. Eleven families who had just been told the fire that killed them had been opened on a schedule, from a wheel on a wall, because a hearth needed filling.

“And him?” she said.

“Removed. He’ll be tried before the full assembly. They think the trial will take a year.” Tobin’s voice did not change. “He hasn’t recanted. He said it again today, to the assembly’s face. That a wild season is coming — a real one — and that when it comes the city will be glad it kept a Guild worth having. He said he kept it that way. He isn’t wrong that the season is coming.”

“No,” Priska said. “He isn’t.”

“He’s wrong about everything else.” Tobin looked down at his hands. The grease from the regulator wheels was long gone, but she saw him check for it. “He never tried to find another way. The assembly asked him that too. He said there wasn’t one. They asked him whether he had looked. He didn’t answer.”

The wind came over the wall of the yard and moved the loose frost on the stone.

“The Guild stays,” Tobin said. “The hearths stay. They can’t not stay — the city would freeze by midwinter. But it’s under the assembly now. An inspector in the hearth chamber every binding, from the city, not from us. The regulators are sealed with lead and the prefect’s stamp. Every release has to be signed by two people who aren’t Guild. And the city records hall keeps the only official account of the Blaze. The prefect’s reports. Not ours.”

“And you?”

“They offered me the archive transfer,” he said. “Someone has to read the Guild’s shorthand into plain language for the assembly’s clerks. It will take the winter. Probably longer.” He said it without any pride, and without any complaint. “I’m still a senior apprentice. That won’t change for a while. I didn’t ask it to.”

She nodded.

Neither of them said anything for a time. It was not an uncomfortable silence. They had spent a great deal of the last season in rooms where neither of them spoke, and they had learned what the silences meant.

“Kessel is in the hearing record,” Tobin said at last. “By name. As a witness to the east-pass smoke. They asked if she wanted to attend and give testimony in person.” A small, dry pause. “She sent back a note saying she’d already told the Guild once, sixty years ago, and didn’t see the need to repeat herself.”

It was the nearest thing to a joke she had heard from him all season. Priska found that she was almost smiling.

* * *

She went down to the lower pass district the next afternoon.

The streets were colder than they had been at the end of the dry season, but not cold in the way the city had feared. The iron grates along the market lane still breathed their faint warmth into the air. The hearth under the square was full. Smoke went up from a few chimneys where people had lit wood fires anyway, out of an uncertainty that would take more than one winter to settle. A man selling roasted chestnuts at the corner had set his brazier directly over a street grate, as street sellers always did, and was doing good business.

Kessel opened the door before Priska had finished knocking.

“You look cold,” Kessel said. “Come in.”

The house was as warm as it had been on the first courtesy call, the hearth connection running high. Kessel settled into her chair by the hearth. Priska sat in the other one. She took off her gloves, and Kessel’s eyes went to her left wrist, where the cuff had ridden up far enough to show the new branching of the second Mark running up the inside of her forearm.

“That’s new,” Kessel said.

“From the final binding.”

Kessel studied it with the same attention she had given the first one. “Oren’s second came up the same way. Along the inside of the arm. He said it itched for a month.” She did not ask anything else about it. She had been in the square. The whole city had been in the square.

Priska told her what the city records hall had confirmed, because Kessel deserved to hear it from

someone and not only from a clerk's letter. The prefect's first-sighting report: first smoke, high east pass, first bell. The building register: a vent shaft for thermal pressure regulation, installed the year before the Blaze. The four Guild witnesses to a western ignition who appeared in no other record the Guild had ever kept. The maintenance log. The finding of the assembly: that the Great Wild Blaze had begun in the east pass, where a twelve-year-old girl on a rooftop had seen it begin.

Kessel listened without surprise. When Priska had finished, she was quiet for a while, looking at the hearth.

"I knew I wasn't misremembering," she said.

Priska waited.

"I wish I'd said so louder."

"There would have been no record to support you," Priska said. "The Guild's account was the only one anyone read. Nobody had pulled the prefect's report in sixty years."

"Yes," Kessel said. "I know."

The silence that followed was long. It did not need filling. Priska let it be exactly as long as it was. Outside, a cart went by on the frozen street, and a child shouted something at another child, and the wind moved against the window.

Then Kessel got up and made tea.

* * *

The assembly's letter came four days later. It confirmed what Ferath had already told her in the corridor: that the reformed roster of the Guild of Binders was being drawn up under city oversight, that every serving binder and apprentice had been reviewed, and that Priska Emberlyn was invited to remain.

It did not offer her a title. It did not mention the final binding. It listed her as a second-year apprentice, pending her third-year assessment in the spring, assigned to seasonal approach work and to second-term instruction. She was the youngest name on the roster by a year and a half.

She signed it at her writing board, in the room that had been searched, with the loose plank under the bed nailed back into place. Then she took it down to the administrative office herself and handed it to the clerk.

Her mother came up the pass that evening with bread from the market and a jar of the salve she sold at her stall for burns and chapped hands, and sat on the end of Priska's bed while Priska rubbed it into the new Mark. Her mother did not ask what it had felt like to stand on the platform. She did not ask why Priska was staying. She said the salve would help with the itch, and that the dye works had been busy all week because people wanted warm colours for the

winter, and that Priska's father sent his love and a scarf he had dyed himself, which was the colour of rust and not quite even along one edge. Priska wore it to the practice yard the next morning.

She did not know yet what the Marks were worth. Two of them now, grey-black, branching from the wrist, permanent. Both earned the way she had been taught to earn them: close range, palms to the stone, the posture held until the spirit transited. The labour had been real. The danger had been real. The heat that was even now keeping the aqueducts from freezing had come through her hands, and the people drinking that water had never been lied to by the water.

The fires that sent those spirits had been opened from a wheel on a wall.

She had turned it over for three weeks and had not found an answer, and she had begun to suspect she was not meant to. It was a question she would carry the way the city would carry its eleven names. Not solved. Only kept, and looked at, and not allowed to be forgotten.

* * *

At dusk, three of the first-years stayed behind in the practice yard when the others went in to eat.

Priska had not asked them to. They came to the ramp on their own, red-handed with cold, and asked if they could run the drill again, and she said yes, and filled the bucket.

She did not teach them the official protocol. The official protocol was still being rewritten by people in rooms she would never be asked into, and it would be a year before it was finished, and longer before anyone knew whether it held. She taught them the thing she knew. She had them close their eyes and put their palms flat against the scored stone at the foot of the ramp while she poured, and feel the water arrive — where it was going, where it wasn't, whether it tested the ground or already knew its path. She taught them to say what they felt out loud, plainly, without apologising for it. She taught them to trust what their hands told them before they trusted the manual, and then to go and check the manual anyway.

The smallest of the three, a girl from the lower pass district with a scarf wound twice around her neck, took her hands off the stone and looked up.

"What's the point of learning this?" she asked. It was not insolent. It was the question of someone who genuinely wanted to know. "The fires come from the mountain anyway."

Priska looked at her for a moment.

"They don't, always," she said. "Now you know to ask."

She filled the bucket again. The girl put her hands back on the stone.

Behind them, the lamps were being lit along the pass. In every building from the Guild Hall down to the market lane, the windows had begun to glow with the steady warmth of the containment

hearths — the same warmth the city had lived inside for sixty years, carried up now through pipes that were inspected, through regulators sealed with lead, past a ledger that two strangers had to sign.

It was the beginning of winter.

Priska poured, and the water ran down the stone, and three apprentices bent their heads and felt for the difference.

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